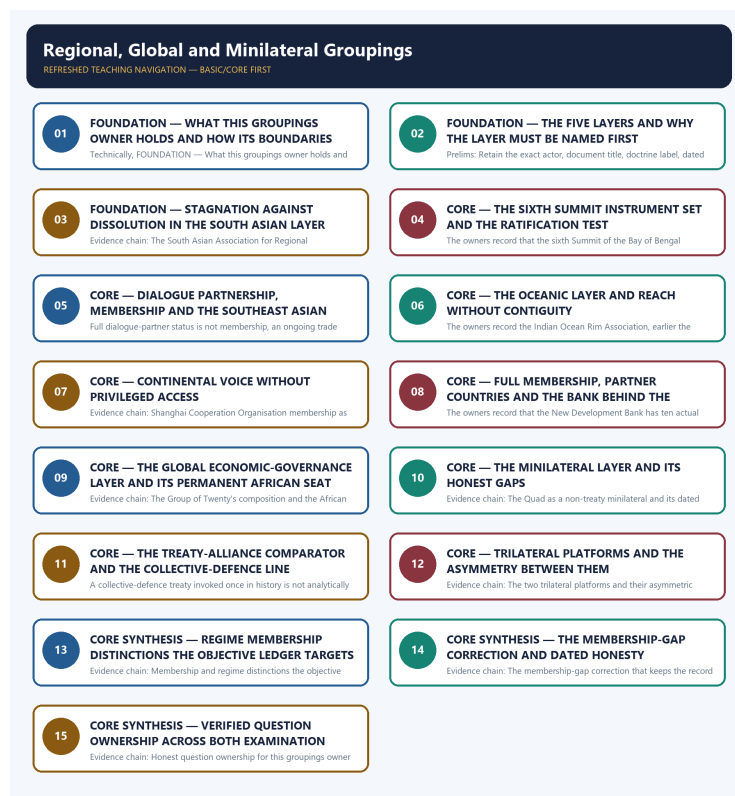


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings - Learner-v2

Complete Learning Session

Authoring-only generation: 2026-09-03. No PDF was rendered and no tracker or index was mutated.

SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT

- **Generation date:** 2026-09-03.
- **Repository-first evidence:** the Basic owner is taught first and preserved in full; the Advanced owner is retained only in the optional final teaching block.
- **OCR evidence:** Repository Markdown was primary. The OCR-searchable official General Studies question papers held under books\mains and books\more_previous_papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of routed demands. No official answer key, marking scheme, page precision or unsupported quotation was imported from them.
- **Qdrant:** not used; repository Markdown and available OCR context were sufficient.
- **PYQ integrity:** Six General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word-limit provenance exactly as observed: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, 15 marks with the 250-word limit printed in the question; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, 10 marks with the 150-word limit printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, 15 marks with the 250-word limit printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, 10 marks; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, 15 marks. For all six the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership. Two provenance facts are reported rather than repaired: the 2020 General Studies Paper II is not among the locally held official papers, so that stem is carried from the audited ledger and the Basic owner and is expressly not confirmed here; and the two 2023 demands print only the mark value in their per-question tail, so their word limits are taken from that paper's own instruction block, which states that answers to Questions 1 to 10 should be in 150 words and answers to Questions 11 to 20 in 250 words. The 2021, 2022 and 2023 stems were confirmed word for word against the locally held official General Studies Paper II question papers for those years. The objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from the audited 2018-2023 papers, four from the audited 2024-2025 papers and three from the audited 2026 paper to this owner, covering Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences, India's Additional Protocol, ASEAN free-trade partners, separatist regions matched to countries, Group of Twenty membership, India's membership of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, the Missile Technology Control Regime and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Organization of Turkic States, country-event pairs, the European Union Trade and Technology Council, the European Union Stability and Growth Pact, the Group of Twenty's origin as a finance ministers' platform, North Atlantic Treaty Organization membership, the Bay of Bengal grouping, the sixteenth BRICS Summit at Kazan and BRICS membership, India-ASEAN multimodal connectivity corridors, BIMSTEC institutional centres matched to their locations and European Union membership status among selected European states. The official 2018-2023 objective keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key held locally is provisional, and in every case no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded, so none of these objective demands is converted into a solved answer. The Basic and Advanced owners also record that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers names one of these groupings as its sole framing device, and that absence is stated honestly instead of force-fitting an adjacent question. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording and word-limit provenance of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.

- **Live-link boundary:** Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for this topic: the Ministry of External Affairs pages first, then the secretariats of the groupings themselves, then the treaty-alliance comparator. Every outcome is recorded exactly as observed. The Ministry of External Affairs press-release, bilateral-document and country-brief pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page, the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, the BIMSTEC Secretariat returned HTTP 404 on its about page and unreadable markup on its home page, the ASEAN membership page returned a redirect without a Location header, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation pages returned only title lines, the Group of Twenty page returned HTTP 403 and the BRICS chairship site failed with a host-resolution error, so no grouping membership, participation tier, summit outcome or chairship claim was obtained from any of them. The two North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages did return substantive official text, and they are used here only for the founding and Article 5 facts those pages actually state. The package therefore uses the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners together with that single verified alliance source, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no grouping membership or accession, no observer, partner, dialogue-partner or guest status, no charter, treaty or agreement provision, no signature, ratification or entry-into-force date, no summit, declaration or vision document outcome, no chairship or presidency claim, no trade, investment or financing figure, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.
- **Fact/inference discipline:** no current-affairs item, PYQ wording, figure or quotation is invented.

LIVE OFFICIAL-SOURCE ATTEMPT LOG

Every live check below was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for International Relations: Ministry of External Affairs official pages first, then other official government or international-organisation documents. Access failures are recorded exactly as observed and no claim is reconstructed from a failed fetch.

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.
- <https://bimstec.org/about-bimstec> - attempted 2026-09-03; the BIMSTEC Secretariat page returned HTTP 404, so no charter, membership or centre fact was taken from it.
- <https://bimstec.org/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Secretariat home page could not be simplified to readable text and yielded only site navigation and member-flag links, so no summit, charter or agreement fact was taken from it and the repository owners' dated BIMSTEC anchors were used unchanged.
- <https://asean.org/member-states/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned an HTTP 307 redirect whose response omitted the Location header, so the redirect could not be followed and no ASEAN membership fact was taken from it.
- <https://www.iora.int/en/about/about-iora> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Indian Ocean Rim Association page redirected to its own landing route and returned only a title line, so no membership, dialogue-partner or chairship figure was taken from it.
- https://eng.sectsc.org/about_sco/ - attempted 2026-09-03; the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat page returned only a title line, so no membership, observer or dialogue-partner count was taken from it.
- <https://www.g20.org/en/about-g20/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no Group of Twenty membership or presidency fact was taken from it.
- <https://brics-india2026.in/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request failed with a host-resolution error, so no BRICS chairship theme, calendar or summit claim was taken from it.
- https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/nato_countries.htm - attempted 2026-09-03; the North Atlantic Treaty Organization returned substantive official text recording that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United

States, and that the Treaty was ratified by all twelve parliaments within the following five months. That text is used only for those founding facts.

- https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_110496.htm - attempted 2026-09-03; the North Atlantic Treaty Organization returned substantive official text recording that the 11 September 2001 attacks led NATO to take action under Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001, and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven NATO airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 NATO countries and over 360 sorties. That text is used only for the treaty-alliance comparison and no Indian or Quad claim was taken from it.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete International Relations Basic/Core is answer-complete before optional Advanced depth.
Status boundary	Announced, negotiated, initialled, signed, ratified, entered into force, operational, suspended and completed remain distinct.
Institutional method	Treaty basis or political character -> exact membership/status -> mandate -> decision rule -> national instrument -> implementation -> outcome.
Level mapping	Bilateral, subregional/regional, minilateral/plurilateral and systemic levels are separated and then connected.
Policy method	Strategic objective -> chosen instrument -> implementing actors/resources -> observed output/outcome -> alternative and residual risk.
Evidence method	Claim -> named India-centric treaty, institution, corridor, operation, agreement or summit -> analysis -> official source/date/status and causal qualification.
Neutrality method	Contested borders, maritime claims and conflicts are attributed neutrally; policy doctrine is distinguished from retrospective analytical label.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, a detailed examiner-grade model, executable timed/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\basic\10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md **Substantive canonical provenance owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings_Learner-V2-Complete-Topic-Package.md **Optional Advanced owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\advanced\10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md **Official syllabus mapping:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International Relations\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Membership discipline:** member, observer, dialogue partner, chair, guest and invited participant are not interchangeable; verify the relevant date.
- **Mandate discipline:** treaty organisation, UN organ, specialised agency, court, summit process, political forum, coalition and minilateral retain exact legal character and competence.
- **Agreement discipline:** announcement, negotiation, signature, ratification, entry into force, domestic implementation and measured outcome remain separate.
- **Connectivity discipline:** concept, financing, contract, construction, trial movement, operational segment, completed corridor and commercially viable use remain separate.

- **Conflict discipline:** distinguish verified event, party claim, independent attribution, legal characterisation and analytical inference; use neutral language for contested borders and conflicts.
- **Causal discipline:** chronology, summit language, trade change, deployment or project completion does not alone establish strategic effect; state mechanism, counterfactual and alternatives.
- **Trade-off discipline:** interests, capabilities, constraints, partner agency, escalation, dependence, finance, legitimacy, domestic distribution, alternatives and implementation risks are explicit.
- **PYQ discipline:** exact wording is preserved only where verified; routed or reconstructed demands remain labelled and no model is presented as an official UPSC answer.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-03:** volatile relations, agreements, corridors, operations, conflicts, trade and summit outcomes retain official source, publication date and operative/interim/completed status; stale officeholders are omitted.

Generation-local live/current sources:

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.
- <https://bimstec.org/about-bimstec> - attempted 2026-09-03; the BIMSTEC Secretariat page returned HTTP 404, so no charter, membership or centre fact was taken from it.
- <https://bimstec.org/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the Secretariat home page could not be simplified to readable text and yielded only site navigation and member-flag links, so no summit, charter or agreement fact was taken from it and the repository owners' dated BIMSTEC anchors were used unchanged.
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- https://eng.sectsco.org/about_sco/ - attempted 2026-09-03; the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation Secretariat page returned only a title line, so no membership, observer or dialogue-partner count was taken from it.
- <https://www.g20.org/en/about-g20/> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no Group of Twenty membership or presidency fact was taken from it.
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- https://www.nato.int/cps/en/natohq/topics_110496.htm - attempted 2026-09-03; the North Atlantic Treaty Organization returned substantive official text recording that the 11 September 2001 attacks led NATO to take action under Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001, and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven NATO airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 NATO countries and over 360 sorties. That text is used only for the treaty-alliance comparison and no Indian or Quad claim was taken from it.



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - WHAT THIS GROUPINGS OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

Technical definition: Technically, FOUNDATION - What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed is analysed by relating FOUNDATION to What this groupings owner holds, then testing the relationship through how its boundaries are routed and Evidence chain.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION

- What this groupings owner holds
- how its boundaries are routed
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- This

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define What this groupings owner holds, connect how its boundaries are routed with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

WHAT THIS GROUPINGS OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

01. What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

BOUNDARY -> Quad maritime security belongs to topic 04, Shanghai Cooperation Organisation connectivity to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and Bretton Woods reform linkage to topic 12.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Quad maritime security belongs to topic 04, Shanghai Cooperation Organisation connectivity to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and Bretton Woods reform linkage to topic 12.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
- **Qualified use:** Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - WHAT THIS GROUPINGS OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

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v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • What this groupings owner holds • how its boundaries are routed •
Evidence chain • Qualified use • This

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Mains: Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a groupings demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - THE FIVE LAYERS AND WHY THE LAYER MUST BE NAMED FIRST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

Technical definition: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The five layers and why the layer must be named first, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **FOUNDATION**
- **The five layers**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **India**
- **South Asian Association**

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define The five layers, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use India for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE FIVE LAYERS AND WHY THE LAYER MUST BE NAMED FIRST

01. The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping

BOUNDARY -> A grouping's layer decides its membership logic, mandate and achievable outcome, so an uncategorised list concedes the comparison marks.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A grouping's layer decides its membership logic, mandate and achievable outcome, so an uncategorised list concedes the comparison marks.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The five layers and why the layer must be named first, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Convert a list of acronyms into a classification that a comparison question actually rewards.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping
- **Qualified use:** Convert a list of acronyms into a classification that a comparison question actually rewards.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - THE FIVE LAYERS AND WHY THE LAYER MUST BE NAMED FIRST

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - The five layers and why the layer must be named first

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v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · The five layers · Evidence chain · Qualified use · India · South Asian Association

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The five layers and why the layer must be named first, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Evidence chain: The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping
Qualified use: Convert a list of acronyms into a classification that a comparison question actually rewards.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached...

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - STAGNATION AGAINST DISSOLUTION IN THE SOUTH ASIAN LAYER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution - The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it
Qualified use: Answer a South Asian regionalism question with a dated institutional record instead of an asserted collapse.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **FOUNDATION**
- **Stagnation against dissolution in the South Asian layer**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **South Asian Association**
- **Regional Cooperation**

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define Stagnation against dissolution in the South Asian layer, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use South Asian Association for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

STAGNATION AGAINST DISSOLUTION IN THE SOUTH ASIAN LAYER

01. The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution

|
v

02. The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it
BOUNDARY -> A constrained body still exists, and a renamed body is one lineage rather than two organisations.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.
- The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was

adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A constrained body still exists, and a renamed body is one lineage rather than two organisations.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Stagnation against dissolution in the South Asian layer, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Answer a South Asian regionalism question with a dated institutional record instead of an asserted collapse.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution -> The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it
- **Qualified use:** Answer a South Asian regionalism question with a dated institutional record instead of an asserted collapse.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - STAGNATION AGAINST DISSOLUTION IN THE SOUTH ASIAN LAYER

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - Stagnation against dissolution in the South Asian layer

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v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • Stagnation against dissolution in the South Asian layer • Evidence chain
• Qualified use • South Asian Association • Regional Cooperation

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution - The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it Qualified use: Answer a South Asian regionalism question with a dated institutional record instead of an asserted collapse.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A constrained body still exists, and a renamed body is one lineage rather than two organisations.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

SESSION 4 - CORE - THE SIXTH SUMMIT INSTRUMENT SET AND THE RATIFICATION TEST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030 - Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum Qualified use: Show exactly where regional integration slows, which is the analytical core of a Bay of Bengal comparison.

Technical definition: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030 - Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum Qualified use: Show exactly where regional integration slows, which is the analytical core of a Bay of Bengal comparison.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The sixth Summit instrument set
- the ratification test
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Summit
- Bay

How to use them: Frame the answer through The sixth Summit instrument set; define the ratification test, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Summit for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE SIXTH SUMMIT INSTRUMENT SET AND THE RATIFICATION TEST

01. The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030

|

v

02. Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum

BOUNDARY -> A vision document, rules of procedure and an expert report are not treaty obligations, and partial entry into force is not regional bindingness.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.
- The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A vision document, rules of procedure and an expert report are not treaty obligations, and partial entry into force is not regional bindingness.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The sixth Summit instrument set and the ratification test, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Show exactly where regional integration slows, which is the analytical core of a Bay of Bengal comparison.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030 -> Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum
- **Qualified use:** Show exactly where regional integration slows, which is the analytical core of a Bay of Bengal comparison.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE SIXTH SUMMIT INSTRUMENT SET AND THE RATIFICATION TEST

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The sixth Summit instrument set and the ratification test

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v

EXACT TERMS: The sixth Summit instrument set · the ratification test · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Summit · Bay

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.

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CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: A vision document, rules of procedure and an expert report are not treaty obligations, and partial entry into force is not regional bindingness.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030 - Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum Qualified use: Show exactly where regional integration slows, which is the analytical core of a Bay of Bengal comparison.

SESSION 5 - CORE - DIALOGUE PARTNERSHIP, MEMBERSHIP AND THE SOUTHEAST ASIAN ARCHITECTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

Technical definition: Full dialogue-partner status is not membership, an ongoing trade review is not a concluded one, and India is not a Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership member.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Dialogue partnership
- membership
- the Southeast Asian architecture
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Association

How to use them: Frame the answer through Dialogue partnership; define membership, connect the Southeast Asian architecture with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

DIALOGUE PARTNERSHIP, MEMBERSHIP AND THE SOUTHEAST ASIAN ARCHITECTURE

01. The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework

BOUNDARY -> Full dialogue-partner status is not membership, an ongoing trade review is not a concluded one, and India is not a Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership member.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Full dialogue-partner status is not membership, an ongoing trade review is not a concluded one, and India is not a Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership member.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Dialogue partnership, membership and the Southeast Asian architecture, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Secure the tier and trade-architecture distinctions that the objective ledger targets repeatedly.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework
- **Qualified use:** Secure the tier and trade-architecture distinctions that the objective ledger targets repeatedly.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - DIALOGUE PARTNERSHIP, MEMBERSHIP AND THE SOUTHEAST ASIAN ARCHITECTURE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Dialogue partnership, membership and the Southeast Asian architecture

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v

EXACT TERMS: Dialogue partnership • membership • the Southeast Asian architecture • Evidence chain
• Qualified use • Association

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework
Qualified use: Secure the tier and trade-architecture distinctions that the objective ledger targets repeatedly.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Full dialogue-partner status is not membership, an ongoing trade review is not a concluded one, and India is not a Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership member.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

SESSION 6 - CORE - THE OCEANIC LAYER AND REACH WITHOUT CONTIGUITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer
Qualified use: Evidence trans-regional reach with a named body, its Secretariat and one dated ministerial outcome.

Technical definition: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The oceanic layer
- reach without contiguity
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Indian Ocean Rim Association
- Regional Cooperation

How to use them: Frame the answer through The oceanic layer; define reach without contiguity, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Indian Ocean Rim Association for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE OCEANIC LAYER AND REACH WITHOUT CONTIGUITY

01. The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer

BOUNDARY -> Twenty-three member states and twelve dialogue partners are separate tiers, and a chair term is not institutional power.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Twenty-three member states and twelve dialogue partners are separate tiers, and a chair term is not institutional power.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The oceanic layer and reach without contiguity, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

- **Mains:** Evidence trans-regional reach with a named body, its Secretariat and one dated ministerial outcome.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer
- **Qualified use:** Evidence trans-regional reach with a named body, its Secretariat and one dated ministerial outcome.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE OCEANIC LAYER AND REACH WITHOUT CONTIGUITY

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The oceanic layer and reach without contiguity

|

v

EXACT TERMS: The oceanic layer · reach without contiguity · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Indian Ocean Rim Association · Regional Cooperation

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer Qualified use: Evidence trans-regional reach with a named body, its Secretariat and one dated ministerial outcome.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Twenty-three member states and twelve dialogue partners are separate tiers, and a chair term is not institutional power.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

SESSION 7 - CORE - CONTINENTAL VOICE WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access Qualified use: Answer the routed Shanghai Cooperation Organisation demands with interests and constraints held together.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access Qualified use: Answer the routed Shanghai Cooperation Organisation demands with interests and constraints held together.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Continental voice without privileged access**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**

- Shanghai Cooperation Organisation
- Eurasian
- China

How to use them: Frame the answer through Continental voice without privileged access; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Shanghai Cooperation Organisation to explain the mechanism, and use Eurasian for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

CONTINENTAL VOICE WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS

01. Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access

BOUNDARY -> Common membership never implies common threat perceptions when Pakistan and China sit in the same body.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Common membership never implies common threat perceptions when Pakistan and China sit in the same body.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Continental voice without privileged access, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Answer the routed Shanghai Cooperation Organisation demands with interests and constraints held together.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access
- **Qualified use:** Answer the routed Shanghai Cooperation Organisation demands with interests and constraints held together.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - CONTINENTAL VOICE WITHOUT PRIVILEGED ACCESS

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Continental voice without privileged access

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v

EXACT TERMS: Continental voice without privileged access · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Shanghai Cooperation Organisation · Eurasian · China

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access Qualified use.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access Qualified use.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access Qualified use: Answer the routed Shanghai Cooperation Organisation demands with interests and constraints held together.

SESSION 8 - CORE - FULL MEMBERSHIP, PARTNER COUNTRIES AND THE BANK BEHIND THE GROUPING

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Partner countries stay outside the membership count, a chairship launch is not a summit outcome and a prospective bank member is not an actual one.

Technical definition: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Partner countries stay outside the membership count, a chairship launch is not a summit outcome and a prospective bank member is not an actual one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Full membership
- partner countries
- the bank behind the grouping
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- BRICS

How to use them: Frame the answer through Full membership; define partner countries, connect the bank behind the grouping with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

FULL MEMBERSHIP, PARTNER COUNTRIES AND THE BANK BEHIND THE GROUPING

01. BRICS full membership against the partner-country category

|
v

02. The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership

BOUNDARY -> Partner countries stay outside the membership count, a chairship launch is not a summit outcome and a prospective bank member is not an actual one.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.
- The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Partner countries stay outside the membership count, a chairship launch is not a summit outcome and a prospective bank member is not an actual one.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Full membership, partner countries and the bank behind the grouping, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Avoid the single counting error that undermines an otherwise sound BRICS answer.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** BRICS full membership against the partner-country category -> The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership
- **Qualified use:** Avoid the single counting error that undermines an otherwise sound BRICS answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - FULL MEMBERSHIP, PARTNER COUNTRIES AND THE BANK BEHIND THE GROUPING

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Full membership, partner countries and the bank behind the grouping

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v

EXACT TERMS: Full membership · partner countries · the bank behind the grouping · Evidence chain · Qualified use · BRICS

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Evidence chain: BRICS full membership against the partner-country category - The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership Qualified use: Avoid the single counting error that undermines an otherwise sound BRICS answer.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Partner countries stay outside the membership count, a chairship launch is not a summit outcome and a prospective bank member is not an actual one.

SESSION 9 - CORE - THE GLOBAL ECONOMIC-GOVERNANCE LAYER AND ITS PERMANENT AFRICAN SEAT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership Qualified use: Place the global-governance layer correctly instead of treating it as a substitute for formal multilateralism.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The global economic-governance layer
- its permanent African seat
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Group
- Twenty

How to use them: Frame the answer through The global economic-governance layer; define its permanent African seat, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Group for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE GLOBAL ECONOMIC-GOVERNANCE LAYER AND ITS PERMANENT AFRICAN SEAT

01. The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership

BOUNDARY -> Guests and invited organisations are not members, and this forum runs parallel to United Nations engagement rather than replacing it.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Guests and invited organisations are not members, and this forum runs parallel to United Nations engagement rather than replacing it.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The global economic-governance layer and its permanent African seat, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Place the global-governance layer correctly instead of treating it as a substitute for formal multilateralism.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership
- **Qualified use:** Place the global-governance layer correctly instead of treating it as a substitute for formal multilateralism.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE GLOBAL ECONOMIC-GOVERNANCE LAYER AND ITS PERMANENT AFRICAN SEAT

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The global economic-governance layer and its permanent African seat

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The global economic-governance layer · its permanent African seat · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Group · Twenty

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership Qualified use: Place the global-governance layer correctly instead of treating it as a substitute for formal multilateralism.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Guests and invited organisations are not members, and this forum runs parallel to United Nations engagement rather than replacing it.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

SESSION 10 - CORE - THE MINILATERAL LAYER AND ITS HONEST GAPS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record Qualified use: Correct the premise of the 2020 demand before evaluating the coalition's widening functional agenda.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The minilateral layer

- its honest gaps
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Quad
- India

How to use them: Frame the answer through The minilateral layer; define its honest gaps, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Quad for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE MINILATERAL LAYER AND ITS HONEST GAPS

01. The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record

BOUNDARY -> An intended host announcement is neither a held summit nor a formal postponement, so the gap is stated rather than filled.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- An intended host announcement is neither a held summit nor a formal postponement, so the gap is stated rather than filled.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The minilateral layer and its honest gaps, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Correct the premise of the 2020 demand before evaluating the coalition's widening functional agenda.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record
- **Qualified use:** Correct the premise of the 2020 demand before evaluating the coalition's widening functional agenda.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE MINILATERAL LAYER AND ITS HONEST GAPS

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The minilateral layer and its honest gaps

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v

EXACT TERMS: The minilateral layer · its honest gaps · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Quad · India

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record Qualified use: Correct the premise of the 2020 demand before evaluating the coalition's widening functional agenda.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: An intended host announcement is neither a held summit nor a formal postponement, so the gap is stated rather than filled.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan...

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

SESSION 11 - CORE - THE TREATY-ALLIANCE COMPARATOR AND THE COLLECTIVE-DEFENCE LINE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue Qualified use: Answer the 2023 alliance-expansion demand through transmission channels rather than through alliance logic.

Technical definition: A collective-defence treaty invoked once in history is not analytically interchangeable with a non-treaty functional coalition.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue Qualified use: Answer the 2023 alliance-expansion demand through transmission channels rather than through alliance logic.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The treaty-alliance comparator
- the collective-defence line
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Article 5
- 2026-09

How to use them: Frame the answer through The treaty-alliance comparator; define the collective-defence line, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Article 5 for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE TREATY-ALLIANCE COMPARATOR AND THE COLLECTIVE-DEFENCE LINE

01. The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue

BOUNDARY -> A collective-defence treaty invoked once in history is not analytically interchangeable with a non-treaty functional coalition.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A collective-defence treaty invoked once in history is not analytically interchangeable with a non-treaty functional coalition.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The treaty-alliance comparator and the collective-defence line, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Answer the 2023 alliance-expansion demand through transmission channels rather than through alliance logic.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue
- **Qualified use:** Answer the 2023 alliance-expansion demand through transmission channels rather than through alliance logic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE TREATY-ALLIANCE COMPARATOR AND THE COLLECTIVE-DEFENCE LINE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The treaty-alliance comparator and the collective-defence line

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The treaty-alliance comparator · the collective-defence line · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Article 5 · 2026-09

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional unilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A collective-defence treaty invoked once in history is not analytically interchangeable with a non-treaty functional coalition.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue Qualified use; Answer the 2023 alliance-expansion demand through transmission channels rather than through alliance logic.

SESSION 12 - CORE - TRILATERAL PLATFORMS AND THE ASYMMETRY BETWEEN THEM

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity - Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer Qualified use: Cite smaller platforms candidly, which is what separates a read answer from a listed one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Trilateral platforms**
- **the asymmetry between them**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **Sikri**
- **India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Trilateral platforms; define the asymmetry between them, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Sikri for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

TRILATERAL PLATFORMS AND THE ASYMMETRY BETWEEN THEM

01. The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity

|

v

02. Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer

BOUNDARY -> One trilateral met in 2025 while the other has no verified meeting since 2021, and a subregional mechanism is not a corridor project.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.
- The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- One trilateral met in 2025 while the other has no verified meeting since 2021, and a subregional mechanism is not a corridor project.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Trilateral platforms and the asymmetry between them, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite smaller platforms candidly, which is what separates a read answer from a listed one.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity -> Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer
- **Qualified use:** Cite smaller platforms candidly, which is what separates a read answer from a listed one.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - TRILATERAL PLATFORMS AND THE ASYMMETRY BETWEEN THEM

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Trilateral platforms and the asymmetry between them

|

v

EXACT TERMS: Trilateral platforms · the asymmetry between them · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Sikri · India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: One trilateral met in 2025 while the other has no verified meeting since 2021, and a subregional mechanism is not a corridor project.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Evidence chain: The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity - Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer Qualified use: Cite smaller platforms candidly, which is what separates a read answer from a listed one.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - REGIME MEMBERSHIP DISTINCTIONS THE OBJECTIVE LEDGER TARGETS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly Qualified use: Convert regime vocabulary into elimination power in statement-based objective questions.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **CORE SYNTHESIS**
- **Regime membership distinctions the objective ledger targets**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **India**
- **Missile Technology Control Regime**

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Regime membership distinctions the objective ledger targets, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use India for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

REGIME MEMBERSHIP DISTINCTIONS THE OBJECTIVE LEDGER TARGETS

01. Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly

BOUNDARY -> A voluntary export-control arrangement, a country-specific waiver and a safeguards protocol each confer something different from membership.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A voluntary export-control arrangement, a country-specific waiver and a safeguards protocol each confer something different from membership.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Regime membership distinctions the objective ledger targets, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Convert regime vocabulary into elimination power in statement-based objective questions.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly
- **Qualified use:** Convert regime vocabulary into elimination power in statement-based objective questions.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - REGIME MEMBERSHIP DISTINCTIONS THE OBJECTIVE LEDGER TARGETS

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Regime membership distinctions the objective ledger targets

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS • Regime membership distinctions the objective ledger targets •
Evidence chain • Qualified use • India • Missile Technology Control Regime

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly Qualified use: Convert regime vocabulary into elimination power in statement-based objective questions.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that the owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE MEMBERSHIP-GAP CORRECTION AND DATED HONESTY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: CORE SYNTHESIS - The membership-gap correction and dated honesty comprises CORE SYNTHESIS, The membership-gap correction and dated honesty as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest - Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries Qualified use: Build the strategic-autonomy argument on a record that concedes its own limits.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **CORE SYNTHESIS**
- **The membership-gap correction**
- **dated honesty**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **Sikri's**

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define The membership-gap correction, connect dated honesty with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE MEMBERSHIP-GAP CORRECTION AND DATED HONESTY

01. The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest

|
v

02. Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries

BOUNDARY -> A period-specific source claim must be corrected and dated, and deliberate overlap carries real bandwidth and coherence costs.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

- The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A period-specific source claim must be corrected and dated, and deliberate overlap carries real bandwidth and coherence costs.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The membership-gap correction and dated honesty, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Build the strategic-autonomy argument on a record that concedes its own limits.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest -> Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries
- **Qualified use:** Build the strategic-autonomy argument on a record that concedes its own limits.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE MEMBERSHIP-GAP CORRECTION AND DATED HONESTY

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - The membership-gap correction and dated honesty

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · The membership-gap correction · dated honesty · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Sikri's

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest - Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries Qualified use: Build the strategic-autonomy argument on a record that concedes its own limits.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: a period-specific source claim must be corrected and dated.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - VERIFIED QUESTION OWNERSHIP ACROSS BOTH EXAMINATION STAGES

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: IOR-ARC; both SAARC and [ASEAN-linked engagement]" - is the explicit organising principle tying all these layers together.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Honest question ownership for this groupings owner Qualified use: Close the topic by stating exactly which demands this owner owns and at what evidentiary level.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

IOR-ARC; both SAARC and [ASEAN-linked engagement]" - is the explicit organising principle tying all these layers together.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Verified question ownership across both examination stages
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Subject
- Tier

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Verified question ownership across both examination stages, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Subject for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

VERIFIED QUESTION OWNERSHIP ACROSS BOTH EXAMINATION STAGES

01. Honest question ownership for this groupings owner

BOUNDARY -> The 2018-2023 objective keys are not held locally, the 2026 keys are provisional, and no answer letter is recorded or inferred for any of them.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The 2018-2023 objective keys are not held locally, the 2026 keys are provisional, and no answer letter is recorded or inferred for any of them.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Verified question ownership across both examination stages, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Close the topic by stating exactly which demands this owner owns and at what evidentiary level.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Honest question ownership for this groupings owner
- **Qualified use:** Close the topic by stating exactly which demands this owner owns and at what evidentiary level.

COMPLETE BASIC OWNER EVIDENCE BANK

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** SAARC, BIMSTEC, ASEAN, IORA, SCO, BRICS, G20 and Quad - membership, purpose and India's interest in each. **Grounded in:** M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity*; Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy*; Shashi Tharoor, *Pax Indica*; MEA BIMSTEC brief; BRICS Rio Declaration; 00_Master-Framework.md Section 2. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md.

1. Visual foundation



Core proposition: ANALYSIS: India participates in a deliberately overlapping set of regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings, each serving a distinct purpose, rather than anchoring its foreign policy in membership of any single bloc.

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
ANALYSIS: SAARC	The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, India's oldest South Asia-specific regional grouping, whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions in recent years.
FACT: BIMSTEC	FACT: Originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation (BIMST-EC), "since renamed" the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC) - a Bay-of-Bengal-focused grouping that has gained salience as SAARC's momentum has slowed. Its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force 20 May 2024. CURRENT: The 6th Summit (Bangkok, 4 April 2025) adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030 , Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report; Bangladesh took the chair.
FACT: IORA / IOR-ARC	FACT: The Indian Ocean Rim Association (earlier IOR-ARC), a trans-regional forum for Indian Ocean littoral-state economic and security cooperation, explicitly cited by Tharoor as a platform India engages alongside larger bodies under its multi-alignment approach. CURRENT: 23 members and 12 dialogue partners; Secretariat at Ebène, Mauritius; India chairs for 2025-27.
FACT: IBSA	FACT: The India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative, a "potentially significant" trilateral grouping (Sikri) linking three major Southern democracies. CURRENT: A Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025.
FACT: RIC	FACT: The Russia-India-China trilateral grouping, cited by Sikri as one of the trilateral platforms India participates in alongside IBSA. ANALYSIS: The most recent official Indian record located is the 18th Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; no 2025-26 resumption is officially verified.

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: SCO	The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, a Eurasian security-and-economic body with 10 full members (including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus), 2 observers and 15 dialogue partners; CURRENT: its 2025 summit at Tianjin (31 August-1 September 2025) adopted the Tianjin Declaration, and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025-26 (full connectivity/energy treatment in topic 05).
FACT: BRICS	Originally BRIC (Brazil-Russia-India-China), later expanded with South Africa and additional members; CURRENT: the 17th Summit (Rio de Janeiro, 6-7 July 2025) issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration . A separate partner-country category was created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024.
ANALYSIS: Quad	A non-treaty minilateral coalition (US, Japan, India, Australia) with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus, marked by asymmetric treaty relationships among its members (full maritime-security treatment in topic 04). CURRENT: The most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware, on 21 September 2024; the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting was in New Delhi on 26 May 2026.
FACT: G20	The premier global economic-governance forum; FACT: Tharoor's multi-alignment framing explicitly pairs India's G20 role alongside its UN role as parallel, non-exclusive engagements. CURRENT: The African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023; the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025; the United States holds the 2026 presidency.

Current membership, participation tiers and institutional nature (verified 3 August 2026):

Grouping	Full membership	Other participation tiers	Institutional nature
SAARC	8 members	Observers	Charter-based South Asian regional organisation; last Summit 18th, Kathmandu, 26-27 November 2014
BIMSTEC	7 members	-	Charter-based Bay of Bengal regional organisation (Charter in force 20 May 2024)
ASEAN	11 members, including Timor-Leste (admitted at the 47th ASEAN Summit, 26 October 2025)	Dialogue partners (India since 1995 as a full dialogue partner)	Treaty/charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation
IORA	23 member states	12 dialogue partners	Indian Ocean intergovernmental regional organisation; India chairs 2025-27
SCO	10 members, including Iran and Belarus	2 observers (Afghanistan, Mongolia); 15 dialogue partners	Charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation
BRICS	11 full members	10 partner countries (category created 24 October 2024)	Intergovernmental political-economic grouping, not a treaty alliance
G20	19 states plus the European Union and African Union	Guest countries and invited international organisations	Informal premier forum for international economic cooperation
Quad	India, Australia, Japan and the United States	-	Non-treaty consultative minilateral
Mekong-Ganga Cooperation	6 members (Cambodia, India, Lao PDR, Myanmar, Thailand, Viet Nam)	-	Ministerial cooperation mechanism under Act East

ANALYSIS: Read this table as a status list, not a power ranking. Partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest categories confer participation, not the rights and obligations of membership - a distinction UPSC tests directly.

3. How the grouping-participation mechanism works

1. **Regional layer (SAARC, BIMSTEC):** FACT: SAARC represents the historical South Asia-wide framework, while BIMSTEC (renamed from BIMST-EC) has gained relative prominence as SAARC's functioning has been constrained; India invests in both, but increasingly channels South Asia-plus-Southeast Asia connectivity ambitions through BIMSTEC.
2. **Trans-regional layer (IORA, IBSA):** these platforms link India with littoral states across the Indian Ocean (IORA) or with major Southern democracies on other continents (IBSA), reflecting a "beyond the immediate neighbourhood" engagement logic.
3. **Continental/Eurasian layer (SCO):** provides India a seat in a body otherwise dominated by China, Russia and Pakistan, useful for continental dialogue despite mixed membership (topic 05 for connectivity detail).
4. **Global-governance layer (G20, BRICS):** gives India a voice in shaping international economic-governance norms, pursued in parallel with, not instead of, UN engagement.
5. **Minilateral/issue-based layer (Quad, RIC, I2U2):** addresses specific functional interests (maritime security, major-power trilateral dialogue, food/water/energy/technology cooperation) without binding treaty commitments.
6. **Overarching multi-alignment logic:** FACT: Tharoor's own listing - "both the United Nations and the G20; both the... NAM... and the Community of Democracies; both the G77... and... IOR-ARC; both SAARC and [ASEAN-linked engagement]" - is the explicit organising principle tying all these layers together.

4. Institutions and agreements

- CURRENT: ****BIMSTEC Charter** (adopted Colombo, 30 March 2022; entered into force 20 May 2024): **the anchor instrument formalising BIMSTEC's institutional/legal status.** CURRENT: The 6th BIMSTEC Summit (Bangkok, 4 April 2025) **adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, and endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the 28 March 2025 Myanmar-Thailand earthquake.** CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 **and** entered into force on 16 May 2026**, initially among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand. ANALYSIS: A treaty in force among four of seven members - not among the whole grouping. ANALYSIS: The BIMSTEC FTA framework agreement dates from 8 February 2004; no concluded FTA is verified.
- CURRENT: **BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration (17th Summit, 6-7 July 2025):** the anchor current BRICS summit outcome document. CURRENT: A **partner-country** category was created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, and India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026. ANALYSIS: Distinguish full members from partner countries, and a chairship launch from a summit outcome.
- CURRENT: **New Development Bank:** ten actual members - the five founders plus Bangladesh (2021), the UAE (2021), Egypt (2023), Algeria (2025) and Uzbekistan (2026); several other states are listed as prospective, not actual, members.
- CURRENT: **ASEAN-India architecture:** the **22nd ASEAN-India Summit** met at Kuala Lumpur on 26 October 2025 - the same summit at which Timor-Leste became ASEAN's 11th member - and the current framework is the **ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (2026-2030).** ANALYSIS: The AITIGA review remained ongoing, not concluded.
- CURRENT: **IORA:** India assumed the two-year chair in November 2025; the 24th Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communiqué.
- CURRENT: **G20:** the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration; the United States holds the 2026 presidency.
- CURRENT: **Quad:** most recent Leaders' Summit at Wilmington, Delaware, 21 September

2024; most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi, 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework; the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025. ANALYSIS: India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit, but no India-hosted Leaders' Summit - or a formal postponement - is officially verified.

- FACT: **IBSA and RIC**: trilateral groupings explicitly named by Sikri as part of India's overlapping-membership strategy. CURRENT: An IBSA Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025; ANALYSIS: RIC has no officially verified meeting since the virtual 18th Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021.

- ANALYSIS: **Mekong-Ganga Cooperation**: a six-member grouping (Cambodia, India, Lao PDR, Myanmar, Thailand, Viet Nam) linking India with mainland Southeast Asian states under the broader Act East policy; ANALYSIS: the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the 10th, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019.

- FACT: **Book-period membership gap**: Sikri noted that India had not secured APEC or ASEM membership in the period he discussed. India joined ASEM in 2007; therefore only APEC remains a current non-membership example, and its status should be dated whenever used.

5. Indian applications and examples

NATO as an external grouping affecting India

- FACT: NATO is a treaty alliance whose North Atlantic Council decides by consensus and whose Article 5 establishes collective defence. Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the 32nd member in March 2024.

- ANALYSIS: India is neither a NATO member nor treaty ally. NATO expansion and Euro-Atlantic consolidation affect India indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignments, sanctions pressure and the allocation of Western attention.

- ANALYSIS: NATO must not be conflated with Quad: NATO is treaty-bound collective defence; Quad is a non-treaty functional minilateral without an Article 5 commitment.

- ANALYSIS: **Russia transmission**: post-2022 NATO consolidation deepens Russia-West confrontation, increasing pressure on India's defence-spares, energy, payments and diplomatic balancing.

- ANALYSIS: **Europe transmission**: Finland's and Sweden's accession expanded NATO's northern geography and strengthened US-Europe coordination, but can also shift Western attention and defence-industrial capacity toward Europe.

- ANALYSIS: **Technology and sanctions transmission**: closer Euro-Atlantic alignment can tighten export-control, technology and sanctions coordination affecting Indian firms and partnerships.

- ANALYSIS: **Indian response**: diversify defence supply, deepen India-EU and bilateral European ties, preserve issue-based Russia engagement and avoid importing NATO's alliance logic into the Indo-Pacific.

High-yield membership and regime distinctions

- FACT: **MTCR**: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its

35th member on 27 June 2016. Significance: membership gives rule access and can ease legitimate high-technology cooperation. **Limitation**: MTCR is a voluntary export-control arrangement, not a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer.

- FACT: **Nuclear Suppliers Group**: India is **not an NSG member**. Its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce. **Significance**: membership would allow participation in nuclear-export rule-making. **Limitation**: a waiver is not membership; admission requires consensus.

- FACT: **AIIB**: India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder

after China. **Significance:** it supplies finance access and a governance stake in a newer development bank.

Limitation: a large shareholding does not confer unilateral control.

- FACT: **SCO:** India became a full member in 2017.

Significance: it supplies access to Eurasian security and connectivity dialogue. **Limitation:** common membership does not imply common threat perceptions.

- FACT: **IAEA Additional Protocol:** India's safeguards Additional Protocol

entered into force on **25 July 2014**. It applies to India's safeguards arrangement; it does not make India an NPT non-nuclear-weapon State.

- FACT: **ASEAN trade architecture:** ASEAN has separate trade agreements with

China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong. RCEP links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand; India is not an RCEP member. **Limitation:** an ASEAN dialogue or FTA partner is not thereby an ASEAN member.

- FACT: **ASEAN-centred security architecture:** EAS and ARF provide broad strategic/security dialogue, while India's IPOI and the ASEAN Outlook on the Indo-Pacific are complementary voluntary frameworks (topic 04 owns detail).

- ANALYSIS: **Routing caution:** ASEAN partner/FTA identification, the EU Trade and Technology Council, the Stability and Growth Pact and current country-event pairs require exact member/date verification; do not infer them from generic grouping labels.

- ANALYSIS: **PYQ mapping:** no GS-II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers directly names SAARC, BIMSTEC, ASEAN, IORA, SCO, BRICS, G20 or Quad as the sole framing device. State this honestly; use the layered-grouping framework here as the structuring device for any regionalism/minilateralism-themed question.

- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Charter's entry into force (20 May 2024) and the 6th BIMSTEC Summit's adoption of Bangkok Vision 2030 (4 April 2025) are concrete, dateable institutional milestones worth citing for any "regionalism in South Asia" question, given SAARC's relatively constrained momentum (no Summit since the 18th at Kathmandu, 26-27 November 2014).

- CURRENT: The BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration (6-7 July 2025) is the relevant dated reference for any current BRICS-agenda question; India holds the 2026 chairship.

6. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- FACT: BIMSTEC was originally BIMST-EC (Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation) before being renamed.

- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024; the 6th BIMSTEC Summit (Bangkok, 4 April 2025) adopted BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030.

- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand.

- CURRENT: The BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration was issued at the 17th Summit, 6-7 July 2025; BRICS has 11 full members and a separate partner-country category of 10 countries created on 24 October 2024.

- CURRENT: Timor-Leste became ASEAN's 11th member at the 47th ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025; the 22nd ASEAN-India Summit met the same day.

- CURRENT: The African Union became a permanent G20 member on 9 September 2023; the 2025 G20 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025, and the United States holds the 2026 presidency.

- CURRENT: India chairs IORA for 2025-27 and holds the BRICS chairship for 2026.

- CURRENT: The most recent Quad Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026.

- FACT: IBSA (India-Brazil-South Africa) and RIC (Russia-India-China) are trilateral groupings India participates in; an IBSA Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025.
- FACT: The last SAARC Summit held was the 18th, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014.
- FACT: Sikri's APEC/ASEM statement is period-specific: India joined ASEM in 2007, while it is not an APEC member as of 3 August 2026.
- ANALYSIS: Quad membership comprises the US, Japan, India and Australia, with a maritime-security/Indo-Pacific cooperation focus.

7. UPSC traps

- WRONG: SAARC has been formally dissolved. -> SAARC continues to exist as an institution even though summit-level momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; do not assert dissolution without a specific, verified source.
 - WRONG: BIMSTEC and BIMST-EC are two different organisations. -> BIMSTEC is the renamed continuation of BIMST-EC; they are the same institutional lineage.
 - WRONG: Quad is a treaty alliance comparable to NATO. -> It is a non-treaty minilateral coalition with acknowledged asymmetry among members (full treatment in topic 04).
 - WRONG: BRICS and the Global South are synonymous. -> BRICS has a specific, distinct (though expanding) membership; the Global South is a broader category (cross-link to topic 08).
 - WRONG: BRICS partner countries are BRICS members. -> The partner category, created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, confers participation without the rights and obligations of full membership; BRICS had 11 full members and 10 partner countries as of 3 August 2026.
 - WRONG: India's BRICS 2026 chairship means India hosted a 2026 BRICS Summit. -> The 13 January 2026 launch of theme, logo and website is a chairship-process anchor; no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.
 - WRONG: The BIMSTEC maritime transport agreement binds all seven members. -> It entered into force on 16 May 2026 among the four states that had deposited instruments - Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand.
 - WRONG: India holds membership in every major regional/global forum it has sought.
- > APEC remains a current non-membership example; ASEM does not, because India joined it in 2007.

8. CURRENT: Current anchor

- CURRENT: The **BIMSTEC Charter (in force 20 May 2024)**, the ****6th BIMSTEC Summit and Bangkok Vision 2030 (4 April 2025) and the BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration (6-7 July 2025) remain key instruments. India launched its BRICS 2026 chairship logo, theme and website on 13 January 2026****; "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability" is the current chairship anchor, not a new treaty or completed summit outcome.
- CURRENT: Two further dated markers carry the current cycle: the ****entry into force of the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation (16 May 2026, among four members) and the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting (New Delhi, 26 May 2026)****, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and an Indo-Pacific energy-security initiative.

9. PYQ application

- FACT: **2020 GS-II**: "'Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD)' is transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times - Discuss." Correct the premise: Quad is neither a treaty military alliance nor a trade bloc; evaluate its widening functional agenda.
- FACT: **2021 GS-II**: "Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India?" - mandate, interests, constraints.

- **FACT: 2022 GS-II:** "How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics?" - use West Asia, investment, technology and strategic-autonomy dimensions.
- **ANALYSIS:** No 2024-2025 question names one grouping as the sole subject; use the layered-grouping framework and dated BIMSTEC/BRICS anchors.

10. Mains angles

- **ANALYSIS:** Always specify which layer (regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance, minilateral) a grouping belongs to, rather than listing groupings without categorisation.
- **ANALYSIS:** Cite the dated BIMSTEC Charter/Bangkok Vision 2030/BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration rather than an undated "regional cooperation" claim.
- **ANALYSIS:** Distinguish treaty-bound institutions (BIMSTEC, SCO, SAARC) from non-treaty coalitions (Quad, RIC, IBSA, I2U2), and full membership from partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest status.
- **ANALYSIS:** Use Tharoor's explicit multi-alignment pairing list as the organising citation for any "why does India join so many groupings" question.

Answer thesis: India's participation across regional (SAARC, BIMSTEC), trans-regional (IORA, IBSA), continental (SCO), global-governance (G20, BRICS) and minilateral (Quad, RIC) groupings reflects a deliberate, multi-alignment strategy of engaging every relevant platform on its own terms, rather than anchoring foreign policy in a single exclusive bloc.

11. Probable questions

- **ANALYSIS: Prelims:** On what date did the BIMSTEC Charter enter into force?
- **ANALYSIS: Mains (10 marks):** Distinguish SAARC and BIMSTEC as South Asian regional groupings. Why has BIMSTEC gained relative prominence in recent years?
- **ANALYSIS: Mains (15 marks):** "India's participation in overlapping regional, global and minilateral groupings reflects multi-alignment, not indecision." Discuss.

11A. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

Core owns the 2020 Quad, 2021 SCO, 2022 BIMSTEC and I2U2, and 2023 SCO and NATO demands, superseding six older advanced/10 routes.

- **Comparison axes:** membership/status, legal basis, decision rule, geographic scope, mandate, India's interest, delivery and political constraint.
- **Evidence:** SAARC/BIMSTEC, ASEAN, IORA, SCO, BRICS, G20, Quad, I2U2, IBSA, RIC and NATO as an external comparator.

10 marks: classify the grouping and give aims/India interest/constraint. **15 marks:** compare institutions with 4-6 named features. **20 marks:** explain overlapping membership as multi-alignment, assess effectiveness and distinguish treaty alliances, regional bodies and minilaterals.

Reasoned verdict: Groupings serve India when their institutional form matches the problem; multiplying memberships without delivery or status precision creates only diplomatic symbolism.

12. Study links

- **FACT:** Advanced companion: advanced/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md.
- **FACT:** basic/02_India-and-the-Neighbourhood.md - Kaladan, the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway and subregional connectivity that operationalise Act East.
- **FACT:** 00_Master-Framework.md Section 2 - the levels-of-engagement table underlying this topic's structure.

- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 01 for the multi-alignment

vocabulary; topic 04 for Quad's maritime-security dimension; topic 05 for SCO's Central Asia/connectivity role; topic 08 for the Global South/BRICS distinction; topic 12 for G20's global-governance linkage to UN/Bretton Woods institutions.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	66	India-ASEAN connectivity through regional multimodal transport infrastructure projects and corridors	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2026	Prelims GS-I	72	BIMSTEC institutional centres matched with their respective geographic locations	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2026	Prelims GS-I	75	European Union membership status among selected European nation-states	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India-ASEAN connectivity through regional multimodal transport infrastructure projects and corridors
- BIMSTEC institutional centres matched with their respective geographic locations
- European Union membership status among selected European nation-states

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 4

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	Prelims GS-I	87	Country-news pairs (Argentina, Sudan, Turkey/NATO)	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	21	NATO member countries	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	92	BIMSTEC	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	97	16th BRICS Summit (Kazan) and BRICS membership	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Country-news pairs (Argentina, Sudan, Turkey/NATO)
- NATO member countries
- BIMSTEC
- 16th BRICS Summit (Kazan) and BRICS membership

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 17

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	Prelims GS-I	7	Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences for a country	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	33	India IAEA Additional Protocol ratification and implications	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	34	ASEAN free-trade partner countries identification	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	90	Separatist regional areas matched with correct countries in news	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2020	GS-II	19	Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc	Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2020	Prelims GS-I	65	G20 member countries identification and groupings	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2021	GS-II	19	Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India	Critically examine · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	10	BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives	Do you think and how are they similar · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	19	I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics	How will it transform · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	Prelims GS-I	66	India membership in AIIB MTCR and SCO groupings	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2022	Prelims GS-I	83	Organization of Turkic States member countries identification	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2022	Prelims GS-I	87	Countries recent political events Chad Guinea Lebanon Tunisia	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	GS-II	9	Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role	Point out the role · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	19	Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India	What is your opinion with reasons · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	Prelims GS-I	87	USA EU Trade and Technology Council launch objectives	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	Prelims GS-I	89	EU Stability and Growth Pact budgetary deficit obligations	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	Prelims GS-I	100	G-20 origin as Finance Ministers platform India priorities	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences for a country
- India IAEA Additional Protocol ratification and implications

- ASEAN free-trade partner countries identification
- Separatist regional areas matched with correct countries in news
- Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc
- G20 member countries identification and groupings
- Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India
- BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives
- I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics
- India membership in AIIB MTCR and SCO groupings
- Organization of Turkic States member countries identification
- Countries recent political events Chad Guinea Lebanon Tunisia
- Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role
- Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India
- USA EU Trade and Technology Council launch objectives
- EU Stability and Growth Pact budgetary deficit obligations
- G-20 origin as Finance Ministers platform India priorities

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - VERIFIED QUESTION OWNERSHIP ACROSS BOTH EXAMINATION STAGES

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Verified question ownership across both examination stages

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS • Verified question ownership across both examination stages • Evidence chain • Qualified use • Subject • Tier

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Honest question ownership for this groupings owner Qualified use: Close the topic by stating exactly which demands this owner owns and at what evidentiary level.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Regional layer (SAARC, BIMSTEC): FACT: SAARC represents the historical South Asia-wide framework, while BIMSTEC (renamed from BIMST-EC) has gained relative prominence as SAARC's functioning has been constrained; India invests in both, but increasingly channels South Asia-plus-Southeast Asia connectivity ambitions through BIMSTEC.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: IOR-ARC; both SAARC and [ASEAN-linked engagement]" - is the explicit organising principle tying all these layers together.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** Regional, global and minilateral groupings vary by treaty basis, membership, mandate, decision rule, institutionalisation and policy domain; India uses them for security, development, standards, finance and coalition-building without identical obligations.
- **Close distinction:** Member, observer, dialogue partner, guest, chair and invited participant are distinct statuses; summit forum is not organisation, consensus is not unanimity in every institution, minilateral is not necessarily informal, and political commitment is not legally binding treaty obligation.
- **Status / evidence / implementation limit:** Verify current membership and institutional mandate from authoritative sources, date summit outcomes, and separate strategic objective, grouping instrument, national implementation and outcome; test overlap, forum shopping, veto, capacity, legitimacy and partner-divergence risks.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. B. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. C. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. This topic owns India's participation across regional,

trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. C. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. D. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. B. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the

linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. B. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. C. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. D. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping?

A. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. B. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. C. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. B. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. C. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has

held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. C. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. D. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping?

A. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. B. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an

intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. D. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution?

A. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. B. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. C. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. D. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding

regional commitment.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. C. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. D. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution?

A. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. B. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. C. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. D. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution?

A. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. B. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its

2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. D. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it?

A. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. B. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. C. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. D. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than

concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. C. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. D. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. C. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and

connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. C. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communiqué; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. C. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. D. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening

is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030 in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. C. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. C. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. D. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030?

A. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. B. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that

reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. C. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. D. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum?

A. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. B. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs

for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

B. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

D. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum?

A. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. B. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. C. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and

Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. C. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. D. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework?

A. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. B. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communiqué; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to

1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. B. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. C. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods

Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. C. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework?

A. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. B. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer?

A. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. B. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian

intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. C. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. B. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. C. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the

examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. C. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. D. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access?

A. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

B. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

C. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.

D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

B. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the

connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. C. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. D. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified

within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access?

A. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. B. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. C. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. D. The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in

2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies BRICS full membership against the partner-country category?

A. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. B. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was

Q38. Which card should be filed under BRICS full membership against the partner-country category in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. C. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. D. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of BRICS full membership against the partner-country category?

A. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. B. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. C. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. D. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about BRICS full membership against the partner-country category?

A. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. B. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. C. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. D. The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership?

A. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. B. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. C. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. D. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership in an International Relations answer?

A. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that

Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. B. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. C. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. D. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership?

A. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. B. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical

connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. C. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. D. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership?

A. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. B. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. C. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. D. The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure

misstates both institutions at once.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership?

A. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. B. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and

never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. B. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. C. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. D. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership?

A. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. B. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. C. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. D. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership?

A. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. B. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic

Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. C. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. D. The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record?

A. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. B. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. C. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. D. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark,

France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. B. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. C. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its

safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record?

A. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. B. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. C. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. D. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record?

A. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. B. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. C. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. D. The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue?

A. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. B. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. C. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. D. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

Answer: A. Explanation: The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. B. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. C. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: B. Explanation: The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue?

A. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. B. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. C. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: C. Explanation: The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no

collective-defence commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue?

A. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. B. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. C. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. D. The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

Answer: D. Explanation: The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in

Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity?

A. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. B. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. C. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. D. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. The

Q58. Which card should be filed under The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. B. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. C. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity?

A. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. B. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. C. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. D. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity?

A. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. B. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer?

A. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. B. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. C. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. B. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its

dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. C. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. D. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer?

A. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. B. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a

15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. C. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. D. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer?

A. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. B. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association,

what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. C. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. D. The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly?

A. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. B. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body

and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. C. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. D. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly in an International Relations answer?

A. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction

block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. B. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly?

A. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a

comparison question penalises. B. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. C. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. D. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and multilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly?

A. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. B. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest?

A. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. B. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. C. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. D. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest in an International Relations answer?

A. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. B. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. C. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. D. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest?

A. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. B. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. C. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. D. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest?

A. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. B. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. C. The owners sort

every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. D. The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries?

A. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. B. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not

among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Answer: A. Explanation: The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q74. Which card should be filed under Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. B. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. C. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai

Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. D. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Answer: B. Explanation: The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries?

A. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. B. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. C. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: C. Explanation: The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct

interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries?

A. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. B. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. C. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. D. The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

Answer: D. Explanation: The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies Honest question ownership for this groupings owner?

A. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. B. This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12. C. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. D. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Answer: A. Explanation: The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is

printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under Honest question ownership for this groupings owner in an International Relations answer?

A. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. B. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. C. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. D. The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.

Answer: B. Explanation: The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Honest question ownership for this groupings owner?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. C. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are

not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. D. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.

Answer: C. Explanation: The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Honest question ownership for this groupings owner?

A. The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. B. The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. C. The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. D. The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question

19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Answer: D. Explanation: The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Six General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word-limit provenance exactly as observed: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, 15 marks with the 250-word limit printed in the question; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, 10 marks with the 150-word limit printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, 15 marks with the 250-word limit printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, 10 marks; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization

and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, 15 marks. For all six the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership. Two provenance facts are reported rather than repaired: the 2020 General Studies Paper II is not among the locally held official papers, so that stem is carried from the audited ledger and the Basic owner and is expressly not confirmed here; and the two 2023 demands print only the mark value in their per-question tail, so their word limits are taken from that paper's own instruction block, which states that answers to Questions 1 to 10 should be in 150 words and answers to Questions 11 to 20 in 250 words. The 2021, 2022 and 2023 stems were confirmed word for word against the locally held official General Studies Paper II question papers for those years. The objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from the audited 2018-2023 papers, four from the audited 2024-2025 papers and three from the audited 2026 paper to this owner, covering Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences, India's Additional Protocol, ASEAN free-trade partners, separatist regions matched to countries, Group of Twenty membership, India's membership of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, the Missile Technology Control Regime and the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, the Organization of Turkic States, country-event pairs, the European Union Trade and Technology Council, the European Union Stability and Growth Pact, the Group of Twenty's origin as a finance ministers' platform, North Atlantic Treaty Organization membership, the Bay of Bengal grouping, the sixteenth BRICS Summit at Kazan and BRICS membership, India-ASEAN multimodal connectivity corridors, BIMSTEC institutional centres matched to their locations and European Union membership status among selected European states. The official 2018-2023 objective keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key held locally is provisional, and in every case no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded, so none of these objective demands is converted into a solved answer. The Basic and Advanced owners also record that no General Studies Paper II Mains question in the audited 2024-2025 papers names one of these groupings as its sole framing device, and that absence is stated honestly instead of force-fitting an adjacent question. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording and word-limit provenance of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or official answer key was imported.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- FACT: **2020 GS-II**: "'Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD)' is transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times - Discuss." Correct the premise: Quad is neither a treaty military alliance nor a trade bloc; evaluate its widening functional agenda.
- FACT: **2021 GS-II**: "Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India?" - mandate, interests, constraints.
- FACT: **2022 GS-II**: "How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics?" - use West Asia, investment, technology and strategic-autonomy dimensions.
- ANALYSIS: No 2024-2025 question names one grouping as the sole subject; use the layered-grouping framework and dated BIMSTEC/BRICS anchors.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	66	India-ASEAN connectivity through regional multimodal transport infrastructure projects and corridors	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2026	Prelims GS-I	72	BIMSTEC institutional centres matched with their respective geographic locations	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2026	Prelims GS-I	75	European Union membership status among selected European nation-states	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India-ASEAN connectivity through regional multimodal transport infrastructure projects and corridors
- BIMSTEC institutional centres matched with their respective geographic locations
- European Union membership status among selected European nation-states

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2024-2025.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2024-2025 Prelims Set-A keys are present in the repository and CSAT Set-A keys are supplied; even so, no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Years represented:** 2024, 2025
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 4

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	Prelims GS-I	87	Country-news pairs (Argentina, Sudan, Turkey/NATO)	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	21	NATO member countries	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	92	BIMSTEC	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2025	Prelims GS-I	97	16th BRICS Summit (Kazan) and BRICS membership	Objective question; official Set-A key available locally, answer not inferred	Key available locally (official Set-A answer key present); answer not recorded here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Country-news pairs (Argentina, Sudan, Turkey/NATO)

- NATO member countries
- BIMSTEC
- 16th BRICS Summit (Kazan) and BRICS membership

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2018, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 17

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2018	Prelims GS-I	7	Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences for a country	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	33	India IAEA Additional Protocol ratification and implications	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	34	ASEAN free-trade partner countries identification	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2018	Prelims GS-I	90	Separatist regional areas matched with correct countries in news	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2020	GS-II	19	Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc	Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2020	Prelims GS-I	65	G20 member countries identification and groupings	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2021	GS-II	19	Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India	Critically examine · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	10	BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives	Do you think and how are they similar · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	19	I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics	How will it transform · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2022	Prelims GS-I	66	India membership in AIIB MTCR and SCO groupings	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2022	Prelims GS-I	83	Organization of Turkic States member countries identification	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2022	Prelims GS-I	87	Countries recent political events Chad Guinea Lebanon Tunisia	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	GS-II	9	Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role	Point out the role · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	19	Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India	What is your opinion with reasons · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	Prelims GS-I	87	USA EU Trade and Technology Council launch objectives	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	Prelims GS-I	89	EU Stability and Growth Pact budgetary deficit obligations	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2023	Prelims GS-I	100	G-20 origin as Finance Ministers platform India priorities	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- Nuclear Suppliers Group membership consequences for a country
- India IAEA Additional Protocol ratification and implications
- ASEAN free-trade partner countries identification
- Separatist regional areas matched with correct countries in news
- Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc
- G20 member countries identification and groupings
- Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India
- BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives
- I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics
- India membership in AIIB MTCR and SCO groupings
- Organization of Turkic States member countries identification
- Countries recent political events Chad Guinea Lebanon Tunisia
- Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role
- Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India
- USA EU Trade and Technology Council launch objectives
- EU Stability and Growth Pact budgetary deficit obligations
- G-20 origin as Finance Ministers platform India priorities

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2020 Quad PYQ:** reject the question's alliance/trade-bloc premise before evaluating functional expansion.
- **FACT: 2021 SCO PYQ:** assess aims and objectives against India's continental security/connectivity interests and Pakistan-China constraints.
- **FACT: 2022 I2U2 PYQ:** analyse transformation of India's global position through issue-based minilateralism, not bloc alignment.
- **ANALYSIS:** No 2024-2025 question directly names a single grouping. An advanced analytical answer should:
 1. Categorise groupings by layer (regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance, minilateral) rather than listing them undifferentiated.
 2. Distinguish institutional-effectiveness levels (treaty-bound vs. non-treaty).
 3. Cite the BIMSTEC Charter, Bangkok Vision 2030, the BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration and India's BRICS 2026 chairship launch at the correct evidentiary level, and distinguish full membership from partner/observer tiers.
 4. Acknowledge membership gaps (APEC/ASEM) honestly rather than presenting uniform diplomatic success.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 6

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2020	GS-II	19	Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc	Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-II	19	Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India	Critically examine · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	10	BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives	Do you think and how are they similar · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	19	I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics	How will it transform · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	9	Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role	Point out the role · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	19	Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India	What is your opinion with reasons · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc
- Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India
- BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives
- I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics
- Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role
- Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 19

Demand: 'Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD)' is transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times - Discuss. A Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger and in the Basic owner. The 2020 General Studies Paper II is not among the locally held official papers, so this wording is reproduced from the audited ledger and the owner and is expressly not confirmed against an official paper held here.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed, and the absence of a locally held 2020 paper is reported rather than repaired by invented wording.

Model solution: Claim: the premise must be corrected before it is discussed, because the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue is neither a military alliance that it could transform from nor a trade bloc that it could transform into; what the

evidence actually shows is a non-treaty consultative minilateral widening its functional agenda while acquiring no collective-defence obligation and no common external tariff. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships; its most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and its most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, while the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; against this, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record a treaty signed by twelve states on 4 April 1949 at Washington, D.C. and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, whose Article 5 collective-defence commitment has been invoked once in its history, after the attacks of 11 September 2001, with the North Atlantic Council confirming the determination on 2 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist running from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002. Analysis: the widening agenda from maritime domain awareness toward critical minerals, energy security and supply-chain resilience is real and datable, but each new limb is an initiative or framework rather than a ratified instrument, so the coalition gains functional breadth without acquiring either the obligation structure of an alliance or the tariff and rules-of-origin machinery of a trade bloc; the correct description is agenda expansion inside a stable non-treaty form, which is exactly why it remains attractive to a state that protects its strategic autonomy. Qualification: the discussion must concede that the announced Leaders' Summit to be hosted by India is neither recorded as held nor formally postponed, that initiatives announced at a ministerial meeting are announcements rather than delivery, that the coalition's members hold asymmetric treaty relationships among themselves which the grouping does not equalise, and that the maritime-security substance itself is owned by topic 04 and must be cited rather than re-argued here. Why this earns marks: it refuses a false premise instead of arguing inside it, dates every limb of the widening agenda, and uses a verified treaty alliance as the control case that makes the classification decisive.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 19”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the premise must be corrected before it is discussed, because the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue is neither a military alliance that it could transform from nor a trade bloc that it could transform into; what the evidence actually shows is a non-treaty consultative minilateral widening its functional agenda while acquiring no collective-defence obligation and no common external tariff. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships; its most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and its most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, while the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; against this, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record a treaty signed by twelve states on 4 April 1949 at Washington, D.C. and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, whose Article 5 collective-defence commitment has been invoked once in its history, after the attacks of 11 September 2001, with the North Atlantic Council confirming the determination on 2 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist running from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002. Analysis: the widening agenda from maritime domain awareness toward critical minerals, energy security and supply-chain resilience is real and datable, but each new limb is an initiative or framework rather than a ratified instrument, so the coalition gains functional breadth without acquiring either the obligation structure of an alliance or the tariff and rules-of-origin machinery of a trade bloc; the correct description is agenda expansion inside a stable non-treaty form, which is exactly why it remains attractive to a state that protects its strategic autonomy. Qualification: the discussion must concede that the announced Leaders' Summit to be hosted by India is neither recorded as held nor formally postponed, that initiatives announced at a ministerial meeting are announcements rather than delivery, that the coalition's members hold asymmetric treaty relationships among themselves which the grouping does not equalise, and that the maritime-security substance itself is owned by topic 04 and must be cited rather than re-argued here. Why this earns marks: it refuses a false premise instead of arguing inside it, dates every limb of the widening agenda, and uses a verified treaty alliance as the control case that

makes the classification decisive.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 19 **Analysis:**

Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the premise must be corrected before it is discussed, because the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue is neither a military alliance that it could transform from nor a trade bloc that it could transform into; what the evidence actually shows is a non-treaty consultative minilateral widening its functional agenda while acquiring no collective-defence obligation and no common external tariff. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships; its most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and its most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, while the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; against this, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record a treaty signed by twelve states on 4 April 1949 at Washington, D.C. and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, whose Article 5 collective-defence commitment has been invoked once in its history, after the attacks of 11 September 2001, with the North Atlantic Council confirming the determination on 2 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist running from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002. Analysis: the widening agenda from maritime domain awareness toward critical minerals, energy security and supply-chain resilience is real and datable, but each new limb is an initiative or framework rather than a ratified instrument, so the coalition gains functional breadth without acquiring either the obligation structure of an alliance or the tariff and rules-of-origin machinery of a trade bloc; the correct description is agenda expansion inside a stable non-treaty form, which is exactly why it remains attractive to a state that protects its strategic autonomy. Qualification: the discussion must concede that the announced Leaders' Summit to be hosted by India is neither recorded as held nor formally postponed, that initiatives announced at a ministerial meeting are announcements rather than delivery, that the coalition's members hold asymmetric treaty relationships among themselves which the grouping does not equalise, and that the maritime-security substance itself is owned by topic 04 and must be cited rather than re-argued here. Why this earns marks: it refuses a false premise instead of arguing inside it, dates every limb of the widening agenda, and uses a verified treaty alliance as the control case that makes the classification decisive.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2020 General Studies Paper II Question 19", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 19

Demand: Critically examine the aims and objectives of SCO. What importance does it hold for India? (Answer in 250 words). A 15-mark demand whose word limit is printed in the question itself, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger and confirmed word for word against the locally held official paper.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation matters to India as a continental seat rather than as a bloc, so its aims are best assessed against what a charter-based Eurasian body can deliver to a member whose principal rivals sit inside it. Named evidence and example: the owners record it as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and India's parallel platforms in the same portfolio include the Indian Ocean Rim Association, where it assumed the chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027 and whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025. Analysis: the organisation's security and economic aims give India standing in Eurasian dialogue that no bilateral channel supplies, and dated summit documents give an Indian position a multilateral audience, but the same membership that creates the seat also caps its yield, because a body containing Pakistan and China cannot advance India-specific priorities without negotiation and compromise; the critical judgement is therefore that the organisation is valuable as one layer of a diversified portfolio and misleading if treated as a vehicle for India's continental objectives on its own. Qualification: the examination must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document rather than a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that a chairship held by another member is a rotation fact and not a shift in the organisation's mandate. Why this earns marks: it answers both limbs of the question, uses dated documents rather than general claims about Eurasian cooperation, and delivers a graded verdict that names the exact structural reason the body's value is bounded.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 19", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation matters to India as a continental seat rather than as a bloc, so its aims are best assessed against what a charter-based Eurasian body can deliver to a member whose principal rivals sit inside it. Named evidence and example: the owners record it as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and India's parallel platforms in the same portfolio include the Indian Ocean Rim Association, where it assumed the chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027 and whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025. Analysis: the organisation's security and economic aims give India standing in Eurasian dialogue that no bilateral channel supplies, and dated summit documents give an Indian position a multilateral audience, but the same membership that creates the seat also caps its yield, because a body containing Pakistan and China cannot advance India-specific priorities without negotiation and compromise; the critical judgement is therefore that the organisation is valuable as one layer of a diversified portfolio and misleading if treated as a vehicle for India's continental objectives on its own. Qualification: the examination must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document rather than a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that a chairship held by another member is a rotation fact and not a shift in the organisation's mandate. Why this earns marks: it answers both limbs of the question, uses dated documents rather than general claims about Eurasian cooperation, and delivers a graded verdict that names the exact structural reason the body's value is bounded.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 19 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation matters to India as a continental seat rather than as a bloc, so its aims are best assessed against what a charter-based Eurasian body can deliver to a member whose principal rivals sit inside it. Named evidence and example: the owners record it as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and India's parallel platforms in the same portfolio include the Indian Ocean Rim Association, where it assumed the chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027 and whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025. Analysis: the organisation's security and economic aims give India standing in Eurasian dialogue that no bilateral channel supplies, and dated summit documents give an Indian position a multilateral audience, but the same membership that creates the seat also caps its yield, because a body containing Pakistan and China cannot advance India-specific priorities without negotiation and compromise; the critical judgement is therefore that the organisation is valuable as one layer of a diversified portfolio and misleading if treated as a vehicle for India's continental objectives on its own. Qualification: the examination must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document rather than a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that a chairship held by another member is a rotation fact and not a shift in the organisation's mandate. Why this earns marks: it answers both limbs of the question, uses dated documents rather than general claims about Eurasian cooperation, and delivers a graded verdict that names the exact structural reason the body's value is bounded.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 19", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realized by forming this new organisation? (Answer in 150 words). A 10-mark demand whose word limit is printed in the question itself, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger and confirmed word for word against the locally held official paper.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the Bay of Bengal grouping is not a parallel organisation but a differently scoped one whose relative salience has risen as the South Asian association's summit momentum has been constrained, and India's objectives are realised through that difference in scope rather than through substitution. Named evidence and example: the owners record the South Asian association as a charter-based body of eight members with an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and the Bay of Bengal grouping as a charter-based body of seven members whose Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, and which was renamed from the earlier Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri

Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping; the sixth Summit at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report with Bangladesh taking the chair; and the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, signed on 3 April 2025, entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand. Analysis: the similarities are institutional, since both are charter-based regional organisations with overlapping South Asian membership and a technical and economic cooperation mandate; the dissimilarities are decisive, since the Bay of Bengal grouping is organised around a maritime region that links South and Southeast Asia, excludes the bilateral relationship that has constrained the older body, and has produced dated instruments within a single recent cycle, which is precisely what allows India to pursue connectivity and Act East objectives without waiting on a stalled forum. Qualification: the answer must state that the older association continues to exist and has not been formally replaced, that a vision document and rules of procedure are not treaty obligations, that entry into force among four of seven members is not regional bindingness, and that only a framework agreement from 8 February 2004 exists for a free trade area. Why this earns marks: it corrects the parallel-organisation premise, gives similarities and dissimilarities on named institutional axes, and evidences the objective claim with instruments dated inside a single verifiable cycle.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 10”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the Bay of Bengal grouping is not a parallel organisation but a differently scoped one whose relative salience has risen as the South Asian association's summit momentum has been constrained, and India's objectives are realised through that difference in scope rather than through substitution. Named evidence and example: the owners record the South Asian association as a charter-based body of eight members with an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and the Bay of Bengal grouping as a charter-based body of seven members whose Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, and which was renamed from the earlier Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping; the sixth Summit at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report with Bangladesh taking the chair; and the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, signed on 3 April 2025, entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand. Analysis: the similarities are institutional, since both are charter-based regional organisations with overlapping South Asian membership and a technical and economic cooperation mandate; the dissimilarities are decisive, since the Bay of Bengal grouping is organised around a maritime region that links South and Southeast Asia, excludes the bilateral relationship that has constrained the older body, and has produced dated instruments within a single recent cycle, which is precisely what allows India to pursue connectivity and Act East objectives without waiting on a stalled forum. Qualification: the answer must state that the older association continues to exist and has not been formally replaced, that a vision document and rules of procedure are not treaty obligations, that entry into force among four of seven members is not regional bindingness, and that only a framework agreement from 8 February 2004 exists for a free trade area. Why this earns marks: it corrects the parallel-organisation premise, gives similarities and dissimilarities on named institutional axes, and evidences the objective claim with instruments dated inside a single verifiable cycle.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the Bay of Bengal grouping is not a parallel organisation but a differently scoped one whose relative salience has risen as the South Asian association's summit momentum has been constrained, and

India's objectives are realised through that difference in scope rather than through substitution. Named evidence and example: the owners record the South Asian association as a charter-based body of eight members with an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and the Bay of Bengal grouping as a charter-based body of seven members whose Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, and which was renamed from the earlier Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping; the sixth Summit at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report with Bangladesh taking the chair; and the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, signed on 3 April 2025, entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand. Analysis: the similarities are institutional, since both are charter-based regional organisations with overlapping South Asian membership and a technical and economic cooperation mandate; the dissimilarities are decisive, since the Bay of Bengal grouping is organised around a maritime region that links South and Southeast Asia, excludes the bilateral relationship that has constrained the older body, and has produced dated instruments within a single recent cycle, which is precisely what allows India to pursue connectivity and Act East objectives without waiting on a stalled forum. Qualification: the answer must state that the older association continues to exist and has not been formally replaced, that a vision document and rules of procedure are not treaty obligations, that entry into force among four of seven members is not regional bindingness, and that only a framework agreement from 8 February 2004 exists for a free trade area. Why this earns marks: it corrects the parallel-organisation premise, gives similarities and dissimilarities on named institutional axes, and evidences the objective claim with instruments dated inside a single verifiable cycle.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 19

Demand: How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics? (Answer in 250 words). A 15-mark demand whose word limit is printed in the question itself, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger and confirmed word for word against the locally held official paper.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the transformation is real but categorical rather than dramatic, because I2U2 changes the kind of platform through which India acts rather than the quantum of power it holds, moving it from bloc-shaped alignment toward issue-based minilateral coordination. Named evidence and example: the owners classify I2U2, alongside the Quad and the Russia-India-China trilateral, in the minilateral and issue-based layer defined by small self-selected membership around one or two functional issues without geographic contiguity and without binding treaty commitment, and they list its functional field as food, water, energy and technology cooperation; the contrast cases in the same architecture are the charter-based Bay of Bengal grouping, whose Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024, and the non-treaty Quad, whose Foreign Ministers announced initiatives at New Delhi on 26 May 2026 without any ratification step; the same portfolio also carries the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025 to 2027 and the Group of Twenty, where the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023. Analysis: minilateral coordination lets India assemble capital, technology and market access from partners it could not join in a single formal organisation, and it does so without importing the political cost of a bloc, which is why the transformation is best described as an expansion of India's usable instruments rather than a change of camp; the strategic-autonomy payoff is structural, because a portfolio in which no single platform is existentially necessary absorbs stagnation in any one of them. Qualification: the assessment must state that a minilateral produces no treaty obligation and therefore no guaranteed delivery, that West Asian regional exposure and its energy dimension are owned by topic 06 and must be cited rather than re-argued, that announced projects are announcements until dated implementation is shown, and that a small self-selected grouping cannot substitute for the formal institutions where rules are actually written. Why this earns marks: it answers the transformation question in the correct analytical

register, places the grouping inside a named architecture rather than describing it in isolation, and refuses to convert an issue-based coalition into a claim of systemic power.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 19”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the transformation is real but categorical rather than dramatic, because I2U2 changes the kind of platform through which India acts rather than the quantum of power it holds, moving it from bloc-shaped alignment toward issue-based minilateral coordination. Named evidence and example: the owners classify I2U2, alongside the Quad and the Russia-India-China trilateral, in the minilateral and issue-based layer defined by small self-selected membership around one or two functional issues without geographic contiguity and without binding treaty commitment, and they list its functional field as food, water, energy and technology cooperation; the contrast cases in the same architecture are the charter-based Bay of Bengal grouping, whose Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024, and the non-treaty Quad, whose Foreign Ministers announced initiatives at New Delhi on 26 May 2026 without any ratification step; the same portfolio also carries the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025 to 2027 and the Group of Twenty, where the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023. Analysis: minilateral coordination lets India assemble capital, technology and market access from partners it could not join in a single formal organisation, and it does so without importing the political cost of a bloc, which is why the transformation is best described as an expansion of India's usable instruments rather than a change of camp; the strategic-autonomy payoff is structural, because a portfolio in which no single platform is existentially necessary absorbs stagnation in any one of them. Qualification: the assessment must state that a minilateral produces no treaty obligation and therefore no guaranteed delivery, that West Asian regional exposure and its energy dimension are owned by topic 06 and must be cited rather than re-argued, that announced projects are announcements until dated implementation is shown, and that a small self-selected grouping cannot substitute for the formal institutions where rules are actually written. Why this earns marks: it answers the transformation question in the correct analytical register, places the grouping inside a named architecture rather than describing it in isolation, and refuses to convert an issue-based coalition into a claim of systemic power.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 19 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the transformation is real but categorical rather than dramatic, because I2U2 changes the kind of platform through which India acts rather than the quantum of power it holds, moving it from bloc-shaped alignment toward issue-based minilateral coordination. Named evidence and example: the owners classify I2U2, alongside the Quad and the Russia-India-China trilateral, in the minilateral and issue-based layer defined by small self-selected membership around one or two functional issues without geographic contiguity and without binding treaty commitment, and they list its functional field as food, water, energy and technology cooperation; the contrast cases in the same architecture are the charter-based Bay of Bengal grouping, whose Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024, and the non-treaty Quad, whose Foreign Ministers announced initiatives at New Delhi on 26 May 2026 without any ratification step; the same portfolio also carries the Indian Ocean Rim Association chaired by India for 2025 to 2027 and the Group of Twenty, where the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023. Analysis: minilateral coordination lets India assemble capital, technology and market access from partners it could not join in a single formal organisation, and it does so without importing the political cost of a bloc, which is why the transformation is best described as an expansion of India's usable instruments rather than a change of camp; the strategic-autonomy payoff is structural, because a portfolio in which no single platform is existentially necessary

absorbs stagnation in any one of them. Qualification: the assessment must state that a minilateral produces no treaty obligation and therefore no guaranteed delivery, that West Asian regional exposure and its energy dimension are owned by topic 06 and must be cited rather than re-argued, that announced projects are announcements until dated implementation is shown, and that a small self-selected grouping cannot substitute for the formal institutions where rules are actually written. Why this earns marks: it answers the transformation question in the correct analytical register, places the grouping inside a named architecture rather than describing it in isolation, and refuses to convert an issue-based coalition into a claim of systemic power.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2022 General Studies Paper II Question 19”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 5 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 9

Demand: 'Virus of Conflict is affecting the functioning of the SCO' In the light of the above statement point out the role of India in mitigating the problems. A 10-mark demand, confirmed word for word against the locally held official paper, whose printed per-question tail carries only the mark value; the 150-word limit is taken from the paper's instruction block, which states that answers to Questions 1 to 10 should be in 150 words and answers to Questions 11 to 20 in 250 words.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership and where the word limit is recorded as taken from the paper's instruction block. That instruction block was read directly in the locally held official paper and is reported here rather than reconstructed. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the conflict named in the stem operates inside the membership rather than outside it, so India's mitigating role is to keep the organisation functional as a dialogue seat while refusing to let it carry claims its own decision structure cannot support. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and the same five-layer architecture gives India alternatives if this seat yields little, including the Indian Ocean Rim Association, chaired by India for 2025 to 2027, whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025, and the trilateral platforms named by Sikri, of which the Russia-India-China format has no officially verified meeting since the virtual eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021. Analysis: because a charter-based intergovernmental body decides among members with divergent threat perceptions, an unresolved conflict inside the membership converts an ordinary procedural step into a bargaining chokepoint, and the organisation's output migrates toward declaratory language that every member can accept; India's mitigating contribution is therefore threefold, namely sustaining participation for the continental access it supplies, pressing positions such as counter-terrorism and connectivity language that can survive that filter, and building parallel platforms so that no single blocked forum determines its Eurasian standing. Qualification: the answer must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document and not a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that the dormancy of the Russia-India-China format is a verified absence of a recorded meeting rather than an inference about any member's intent. Why this earns marks: it answers the exact directive by pointing out India's role, explains the constraint mechanically instead of describing it, and closes with a bounded judgement that neither overstates Indian influence nor writes the organisation off.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 5 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 9”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the conflict named in the stem operates inside the membership rather than outside it, so India's mitigating role is to keep the organisation functional as a dialogue seat while refusing to let it carry claims its own decision structure cannot support. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and the same five-layer architecture gives India alternatives if this seat yields little, including the Indian Ocean Rim Association, chaired by India for 2025 to 2027, whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025, and the trilateral platforms named by Sikri, of which the Russia-India-China format has no officially verified meeting since the virtual eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021. Analysis: because a charter-based intergovernmental body decides among members with divergent threat perceptions, an unresolved conflict inside the membership converts an ordinary procedural step into a bargaining chokepoint, and the organisation's output migrates toward declaratory language that every member can accept; India's mitigating contribution is therefore threefold, namely sustaining participation for the continental access it supplies, pressing positions such as counter-terrorism and connectivity language that can survive that filter, and building parallel platforms so that no single blocked forum determines its Eurasian standing. Qualification: the answer must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document and not a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that the dormancy of the Russia-India-China format is a verified absence of a recorded meeting rather than an inference about any member's intent. Why this earns marks: it answers the exact directive by pointing out India's role, explains the constraint mechanically instead of describing it, and closes with a bounded judgement that neither overstates Indian influence nor writes the organisation off.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 5 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 9 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the conflict named in the stem operates inside the membership rather than outside it, so India's mitigating role is to keep the organisation functional as a dialogue seat while refusing to let it carry claims its own decision structure cannot support. Named evidence and example: the owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners; India became a full member in 2017; the 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; and the same five-layer architecture gives India alternatives if this seat yields little, including the Indian Ocean Rim Association, chaired by India for 2025 to 2027, whose twenty-fourth Council of Ministers adopted the Colombo Communique on 21 May 2025, and the trilateral platforms named by Sikri, of which the Russia-India-China format has no officially verified meeting since the virtual eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021. Analysis: because a charter-based intergovernmental body decides among members with divergent threat perceptions, an unresolved conflict inside the membership converts an ordinary procedural step into a bargaining chokepoint, and the organisation's output migrates toward declaratory language that every member can accept; India's mitigating contribution is therefore threefold, namely sustaining participation for the continental access it supplies, pressing positions such as counter-terrorism and connectivity language that can survive that filter, and building parallel platforms so that no single blocked forum determines its Eurasian standing. Qualification: the answer must state that common membership never implies common threat perceptions, that a declaration is a summit outcome document and not a binding commitment, that the organisation's connectivity and Central Asia detail is owned by topic 05 and cited rather than duplicated, and that the

dormancy of the Russia-India-China format is a verified absence of a recorded meeting rather than an inference about any member's intent. Why this earns marks: it answers the exact directive by pointing out India's role, explains the constraint mechanically instead of describing it, and closes with a bounded judgement that neither overstates Indian influence nor writes the organisation off.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 5 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 9", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 6 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 19

Demand: 'The expansion and strengthening of NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well for India.' What is your opinion about this statement? Give reasons and examples to support your answer. A 15-mark demand, confirmed word for word against the locally held official paper, whose printed per-question tail carries only the mark value; the 250-word limit is taken from the paper's instruction block, which states that answers to Questions 11 to 20 should be in 250 words.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership and where the word limit is recorded as taken from the paper's instruction block. That instruction block was read directly in the locally held official paper and is reported here rather than reconstructed. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the statement is partly defensible and must be split, because a stronger United States-Europe partnership does open real technology, defence-industrial and market channels for India, while alliance expansion itself transmits costs that a favourable verdict must not conceal. Named evidence and example: the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record the treaty signed by twelve states at Washington, D.C. on 4 April 1949 and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, and record that Article 5 has been invoked once in the alliance's history, after 11 September 2001, with a conditional Council determination on 12 September 2001, confirmation on 2 October 2001, an eight-measure support package on 4 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 involving seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally. Analysis: the benefit runs through convergence, since a coordinated Euro-Atlantic space deepens India-Europe defence, technology and market engagement and multiplies the partners available for supply diversification; the cost runs through three transmission channels the owners name, namely deepened Russia-West confrontation that pressures India's defence spares, energy sourcing, payments and diplomatic balancing, a possible reallocation of Western attention and defence-industrial capacity toward Europe, and tighter export-control and sanctions coordination that can restrict Indian firms and partnerships. Qualification: the opinion must state that India is outside the alliance and analyses transmission rather than membership, that the alliance must never be conflated with the Quad because collective defence is a treaty obligation the Quad does not carry, that the appropriate Indian response is diversification of defence supply, deeper India-Europe ties and issue-based Russia engagement without importing alliance logic into the Indo-Pacific, and that no prediction is offered about any specific future accession or operation. Why this earns marks: it gives a reasoned split verdict instead of a blanket agreement, supports each limb with verified official detail and named transmission channels, and closes with a policy stance that follows from the analysis.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 6 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 19", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the statement is partly defensible and must be split, because a stronger United States-Europe partnership does open real technology, defence-industrial and market channels for India, while alliance expansion itself transmits costs that a favourable verdict must not conceal. Named evidence and example: the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record the treaty signed by twelve states at Washington, D.C. on 4 April 1949 and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, and record that Article 5 has been invoked once in the alliance's history, after 11 September 2001, with a conditional Council determination on 12 September 2001, confirmation on 2 October 2001, an eight-measure support package on 4 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 involving seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally. Analysis: the benefit runs through convergence, since a coordinated Euro-Atlantic space deepens India-Europe defence, technology and market engagement and multiplies the partners available for supply diversification; the cost runs through three transmission channels the owners name, namely deepened Russia-West confrontation that pressures India's defence spares, energy sourcing, payments and diplomatic balancing, a possible reallocation of Western attention and defence-industrial capacity toward Europe, and tighter export-control and sanctions coordination that can restrict Indian firms and partnerships. Qualification: the opinion must state that India is outside the alliance and analyses transmission rather than membership, that the alliance must never be conflated with the Quad because collective defence is a treaty obligation the Quad does not carry, that the appropriate Indian response is diversification of defence supply, deeper India-Europe ties and issue-based Russia engagement without importing alliance logic into the Indo-Pacific, and that no prediction is offered about any specific future accession or operation. Why this earns marks: it gives a reasoned split verdict instead of a blanket agreement, supports each limb with verified official detail and named transmission channels, and closes with a policy stance that follows from the analysis.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 6 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 19 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the statement is partly defensible and must be split, because a stronger United States-Europe partnership does open real technology, defence-industrial and market channels for India, while alliance expansion itself transmits costs that a favourable verdict must not conceal. Named evidence and example: the North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages checked on 2026-09-03 record the treaty signed by twelve states at Washington, D.C. on 4 April 1949 and ratified by all twelve parliaments within five months, and record that Article 5 has been invoked once in the alliance's history, after 11 September 2001, with a conditional Council determination on 12 September 2001, confirmation on 2 October 2001, an eight-measure support package on 4 October 2001 and Operation Eagle Assist from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 involving seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally. Analysis: the benefit runs through convergence, since a coordinated Euro-Atlantic space deepens India-Europe defence, technology and market engagement and multiplies the partners available for supply diversification; the cost runs through three transmission channels the owners name, namely deepened Russia-West confrontation that pressures India's defence spares, energy sourcing, payments and diplomatic balancing, a possible reallocation of Western attention and defence-industrial capacity toward Europe, and tighter export-control and sanctions coordination that can restrict Indian firms and partnerships. Qualification: the opinion must state that India is outside the alliance and analyses transmission rather than membership, that the alliance must never be conflated with the Quad because collective defence is a treaty obligation the Quad does not carry, that the appropriate Indian response is diversification of defence supply, deeper India-Europe ties and issue-based Russia engagement without importing alliance logic into the Indo-Pacific, and that no prediction is offered

about any specific future accession or operation. Why this earns marks: it gives a reasoned split verdict instead of a blanket agreement, supports each limb with verified official detail and named transmission channels, and closes with a policy stance that follows from the analysis.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ DEMAND CARD 6 - 2023 General Studies Paper II Question 19”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Distinguish regionalism from minilateralism as organising principles for India's diplomatic engagement, with reference to dated institutional evidence. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The two principles differ in membership logic, legal form and the kind of outcome each can produce, so the distinction must be drawn on those axes and evidenced with a charter-based regional body and a non-treaty coalition rather than asserted as a definitional contrast.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.
- The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.
- The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.
- The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

Qualified conclusion: The two principles differ in membership logic, legal form and the kind of outcome each can produce, so the distinction must be drawn on those axes and evidenced with a charter-based regional body and a non-treaty coalition rather than asserted as a definitional contrast.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Distinguish regionalism from minilateralism as organising principles for India's diplomatic...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The two principles differ in membership logic, legal form and the kind of outcome each can produce, so the distinction must be drawn on those axes and evidenced with a charter-based regional body and a non-treaty coalition rather than asserted as a definitional contrast.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven

members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The two principles differ in membership logic, legal form and the kind of outcome each can produce, so the distinction must be drawn on those axes and evidenced with a charter-based regional body and a non-treaty coalition rather than asserted as a definitional contrast.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish regionalism from minilateralism as organising principles for India's diplomatic...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Comment on the proposition that the entry into force of the Bay of Bengal grouping's Charter marks a genuine deepening of South Asian regionalism. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The deepening is real but bounded, so the comment must date the Charter, name the instruments the sixth Summit actually adopted, and then use partial entry into force of the maritime transport agreement to show where integration slows.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.
- The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.
- The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest

available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

- The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.

Qualified conclusion: The deepening is real but bounded, so the comment must date the Charter, name the instruments the sixth Summit actually adopted, and then use partial entry into force of the maritime transport agreement to show where integration slows.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on “Comment on the proposition that the entry into force of the Bay of Bengal grouping's Charter...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The deepening is real but bounded, so the comment must date the Charter, name the instruments the sixth Summit actually adopted, and then use partial entry into force of the maritime transport agreement to show where integration slows.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded

free trade agreement verified. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The deepening is real but bounded, so the comment must date the Charter, name the instruments the sixth Summit actually adopted, and then use partial entry into force of the maritime transport agreement to show where integration slows.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Comment on the proposition that the entry into force of the Bay of Bengal grouping's Charter...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine why India's participation in overlapping regional, global and minilateral groupings should be read as multi-alignment rather than indecision. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Overlap is a designed portfolio rather than a lack of choice, so the examination must classify the layers, show that each addresses a non-identical interest, evidence the claim with dated instruments and then concede the coordination and coherence costs honestly.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.
- The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of

both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.

- The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.
- The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

Qualified conclusion: Overlap is a designed portfolio rather than a lack of choice, so the examination must classify the layers, show that each addresses a non-identical interest, evidence the claim with dated instruments and then concede the coordination and coherence costs honestly.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine why India's participation in overlapping regional, global and minilateral groupings...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Overlap is a designed portfolio rather than a lack of choice, so the examination must classify the layers, show that each addresses a non-identical interest, evidence the claim with dated instruments and then concede the coordination and coherence costs honestly.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned

Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Overlap is a designed portfolio rather than a lack of choice, so the examination must classify the layers, show that each addresses a non-identical interest, evidence the claim with dated instruments and then concede the coordination and coherence costs honestly.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine why India's participation in overlapping regional, global and minilateral groupings...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the claim that participation tiers, rather than headline membership, are where the real distinction between these groupings lies. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Tiers are the mechanism by which bodies expand reach without expanding decision rights, so the examination must set out the partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest categories with named examples and show what each does and does not confer.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.
- The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.
- The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.
- The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.

Qualified conclusion: Tiers are the mechanism by which bodies expand reach without expanding decision rights, so the examination must set out the partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest categories with named examples and show what each does and does not confer.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the claim that participation tiers, rather than headline membership, are where the...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Tiers are the mechanism by which bodies expand reach without expanding decision rights, so the examination must set out the partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest categories with named examples and show what each does and does not confer.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic

consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Tiers are the mechanism by which bodies expand reach without expanding decision rights, so the examination must set out the partner, observer, dialogue-partner and guest categories with named examples and show what each does and does not confer.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the claim that participation tiers, rather than headline membership, are where the...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess the proposition that institutional form, and not diplomatic energy, decides what a grouping can deliver for India. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Form largely determines delivery but does not exhaust it, so the assessment must run the treaty-bound to non-treaty spectrum, evidence both ends with dated instruments, and close on the judgement that matching institutional form to the problem matters more than multiplying memberships.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.
- The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.
- The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne

early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.

- The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Qualified conclusion: Form largely determines delivery but does not exhaust it, so the assessment must run the treaty-bound to non-treaty spectrum, evidence both ends with dated instruments, and close on the judgement that matching institutional form to the problem matters more than multiplying memberships.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess the proposition that institutional form, and not diplomatic energy, decides what a...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Form largely determines delivery but does not exhaust it, so the assessment must run the treaty-bound to non-treaty spectrum, evidence both ends with dated instruments, and close on the judgement that matching institutional form to the problem matters more than multiplying memberships.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at

Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or

strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Form largely determines delivery but does not exhaust it, so the assessment must run the treaty-bound to non-treaty spectrum, evidence both ends with dated instruments, and close on the judgement that matching institutional form to the problem matters more than multiplying memberships.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess the proposition that institutional form, and not diplomatic energy, decides what a...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess how India should present the record of its grouping diplomacy without either overstating success or conceding incoherence. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Honesty is itself an analytical asset, so the assessment must name the stagnant body, the asymmetric trilaterals, the surviving membership gap and the unverified summit, and then show why a dated and bounded record supports a stronger strategic-autonomy claim than an unqualified one.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.
- The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.
- The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.
- The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how

Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Qualified conclusion: Honesty is itself an analytical asset, so the assessment must name the stagnant body, the asymmetric trilaterals, the surviving membership gap and the unverified summit, and then show why a dated and bounded record supports a stronger strategic-autonomy claim than an unqualified one.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess how India should present the record of its grouping diplomacy without either...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Honesty is itself an analytical asset, so the assessment must name the stagnant body, the asymmetric trilaterals, the surviving membership gap and the unverified summit, and then show why a dated and bounded record supports a stronger strategic-autonomy claim than an unqualified one.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a

present-day fact. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

Qualification: State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Honesty is itself an analytical asset, so the assessment must name the stagnant body, the asymmetric trilaterals, the surviving membership gap and the unverified summit, and then show why a dated and bounded record supports a stronger strategic-autonomy claim than an unqualified one.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess how India should present the record of its grouping diplomacy without either...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

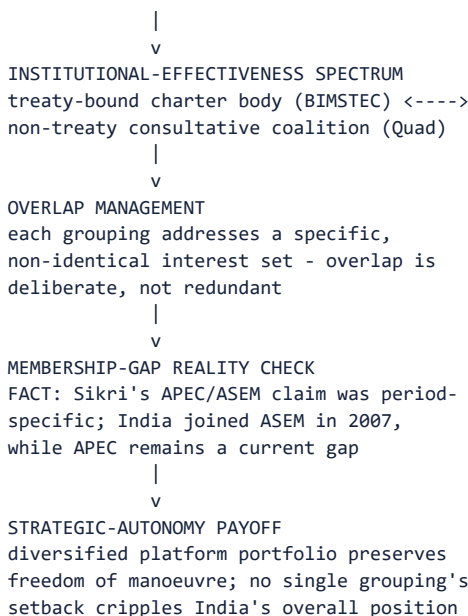
OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** Regionalism versus unilateralism; ASEAN centrality; institutional effectiveness; overlap and strategic autonomy. **Grounded in:** M. Laxmikanth, *Indian Polity*; Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy*; Shashi Tharoor, *Pax Indica*; MEA BIMSTEC brief; BRICS Rio Declaration; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 2, 4 and 7. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md.

1. Architecture

FIVE-LAYER GROUPING ARCHITECTURE

REGIONAL	TRANS-REGIONAL	CONTIN-ENT	GLOBAL-GOVERNANCE	MINI-LATERAL
SAARC, BIMSTEC, Mekong-Ganga	IORA, IBSA	SCO	G20, BRICS	Quad, RIC, I2U2



Analytical claim: ANALYSIS: The advanced analytical task is to explain why overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy: each grouping addresses a distinct interest (regional connectivity, trans-regional maritime cooperation, continental dialogue, global economic governance, or issue-specific minilateral coordination), and failure or stagnation in any single grouping (e.g., SAARC) does not incapacitate India's broader diplomatic architecture.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
FACT: BIMSTEC's institutional evolution (Charter, 2024)	The BIMSTEC Charter's entry into force (20 May 2024) formalises what had operated as a looser cooperative framework since its BIMST-EC origins - an example of regionalism deepening its institutional/legal character over time. CURRENT: The 6th Summit (Bangkok, 4 April 2025) adopted Bangkok Vision 2030, Rules of Procedure and the Eminent Persons Group report.
CURRENT: Partial entry into force as an effectiveness datum	The BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of seven members (Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand) after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026. ANALYSIS: This is the sharpest available illustration that "regional agreement in force" and "regional agreement binding the region" are different claims - and that variable-geometry ratification, not summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows.
ANALYSIS: Regionalism vs. minilateralism	Regionalism (SAARC, BIMSTEC) is defined by geographic contiguity and typically broader membership/mandate; minilateralism (Quad, RIC, I2U2) is defined by a small, self-selected membership around one or two specific functional issues, without requiring geographic contiguity.
ANALYSIS: ASEAN centrality	The principle, widely referenced in Indo-Pacific diplomacy, that ASEAN should remain the organising hub of regional architecture even as external powers (including India, via Act East) deepen engagement - a normative claim ASEAN members themselves actively assert, not a status any external power confers.
FACT: Membership-gap reality (Sikri)	FACT: Sikri's statement that India "failed to get membership of either" APEC or ASEM is a book-period observation, not a current two-forum gap: India joined ASEM in 2007, while APEC remains a current non-membership example as of 3 August 2026.
FACT: Trilateral platforms as autonomy-preserving instruments (IBSA, RIC)	FACT: Sikri frames IBSA and RIC as "potentially significant" - smaller, issue-oriented platforms that let India engage major powers (Russia, China via RIC) or Southern peers (Brazil, South Africa via IBSA) without the constraints of a larger, more heterogeneous body.
ANALYSIS: Institutional-effectiveness spectrum	Groupings range from treaty-bound charter bodies with formal legal status (BIMSTEC post-2024) to loose, non-treaty consultative coalitions (Quad) - analytically distinct categories that should not be conflated when assessing "effectiveness."

Current membership, participation tiers and institutional nature (verified 3 August 2026):

Grouping	Full membership	Other participation tiers	Institutional nature
SAARC	8 members	Observers	Charter-based South Asian regional organisation; no Summit since the 18th (Kathmandu, 2014)
BIMSTEC	7 members	-	Charter-based Bay of Bengal regional organisation
ASEAN	11 members, including Timor-Leste (26 October 2025)	Dialogue partners	Treaty/charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation
IORA	23 member states	12 dialogue partners	Indian Ocean intergovernmental regional organisation; India chairs 2025-27
SCO	10 members, including Iran and Belarus	2 observers; 15 dialogue partners	Charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation
BRICS	11 full members	10 partner countries (from 24 October 2024)	Intergovernmental political-economic grouping, not a treaty alliance
G20	19 states plus the European Union and African Union	Guest countries and invited organisations	Informal premier forum for international economic cooperation
Quad	India, Australia, Japan and the United States	-	Non-treaty consultative minilateral

ANALYSIS: The right-hand columns matter more than the left for advanced analysis: participation tiers are how these bodies expand reach without expanding decision rights - the same asymmetry the Global South contests at the UNSC (topic 12).

3. Detailed causal chain: from overlap to strategic-autonomy payoff

1. Regional groupings anchor the immediate neighbourhood: SAARC's

historical role and BIMSTEC's growing salience (reinforced by its 2024 Charter) both serve South Asia/Bay-of-Bengal connectivity and cooperation goals, even as SAARC's own momentum has been constrained.

2. Trans-regional groupings extend reach beyond contiguous geography:

IORA links India to Indian Ocean littoral states across three continents; IBSA links India to two major Southern democracies on entirely different continents - neither depends on geographic proximity.

3. Continental engagement provides a seat despite mixed membership: SCO

gives India a voice in Eurasian security dialogue despite China, Russia and Pakistan's simultaneous presence - a trade-off between influence and comfort.

4. Global-governance platforms shape norms at the systemic level: G20 and

BRICS let India influence international economic-governance debates (financial-architecture reform, debt, development finance) at a scale no regional body can match.

5. Minilateral coalitions add functional precision: Quad, RIC and I2U2

allow India to cooperate intensively on one or two specific issues (maritime security, major-power trilateral dialogue, food/water/energy/technology) without the compromises a larger, more heterogeneous body would require.

6. Membership-gap experience teaches realistic expectation-setting: FACT:

Sikri's period-specific APEC/ASEM example demonstrates that India's platform-diversification strategy is not uniformly successful, but current status matters: India joined ASEM in 2007, while APEC remains a gap.

7. Net payoff: strategic-autonomy resilience. Because no single grouping

is treated as existentially necessary, stagnation in one (SAARC) or exclusion from another (historical APEC/ASEM gaps) does not compromise India's overall diplomatic position - the multi-alignment logic (topic 01) is structurally embedded in this five-layer architecture.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- CURRENT: **BIMSTEC Charter (in force 20 May 2024) and the 6th Summit (Bangkok,

4 April 2025):** the clearest example of regionalism's institutional deepening within the period covered by this module - Charter, Bangkok Vision 2030, Rules of Procedure and an Eminent Persons Group report in a single cycle.

CURRENT: The Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation (signed 3 April

2025. entered into force on 16 May 2026 among four of seven members.

- CURRENT: **BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration (17th Summit, 6-7 July 2025)**: the

current dated reference for BRICS's evolving agenda (financial-architecture reform, expanded membership considerations) - full financial-institution-reform linkage reserved for topic 12 to avoid duplicating that treatment here.

CURRENT: India holds the 2026 chairship, launched 13 January 2026.

- FACT: **IBSA and RIC**: trilateral platforms whose "potentially significant"

framing (Sikri) reflects an early-stage assessment. CURRENT: An IBSA Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025, proposing an IBSA Digital Innovation Alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund (ANALYSIS: proposals, not established institutions); ANALYSIS: RIC has no officially verified meeting since the virtual 18th Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021 - a candid asymmetry worth stating when the two are listed together.

- CURRENT: **Quad**: most recent Leaders' Summit at Wilmington, 21 September 2024;

most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi, 26 May 2026. ANALYSIS: India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit, but no India-hosted Leaders' Summit - or a formal postponement - is officially verified: an accurate answer states the gap rather than assuming either outcome.

- ANALYSIS: **SCO**: full institutional/connectivity profile reserved for topic 05.

- ANALYSIS: **Quad**: full maritime-security institutional profile reserved for topic

04, where its internal asymmetry (per Tharoor) is analysed in depth.

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - SAARC stagnation vs. BIMSTEC ascendance**: the shift in relative institutional energy from SAARC toward BIMSTEC (reinforced by the 2024 Charter) illustrates how India adapts its regional strategy when one platform's utility declines, rather than persisting with a single, fixed regional-institution preference.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - SCO membership without privileged access**: as in topic 05's treatment, India's SCO membership provides voice but not exclusive influence, given Pakistan's simultaneous membership.

- ANALYSIS: ****Boundary case - membership gaps as a corrective to triumphalist narratives:**** APEC remains a useful current example. Sikri's ASEM reference must be identified as period-specific because India joined ASEM in 2007.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - BRICS expansion and coherence trade-off**: BRICS's membership expansion (beyond the original four/five) raises an analytical question about whether a larger, more heterogeneous membership dilutes or strengthens its collective bargaining power - treat any specific claim about post-expansion BRICS effectiveness cautiously and only with dated evidence.

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: **Overlap has real coordination costs**: engaging five distinct layers of groupings simultaneously requires significant diplomatic bandwidth and can create scheduling/prioritisation trade-offs during any single diplomatic season.

- ANALYSIS: **Institutional-effectiveness variance is a genuine limitation**: a treaty-bound charter body (BIMSTEC) carries different obligations and expectations than a non-treaty coalition (Quad); treating all groupings as equally "effective" or "binding" is analytically imprecise.

- ANALYSIS: **Regional stagnation (SAARC) has real opportunity costs**: even as BIMSTEC gains relative salience, the continued underperformance of the SAARC framework represents an unrealised regional-integration opportunity, not a costless substitution.

- ANALYSIS: **Membership-seeking does not guarantee membership:** APEC remains the current example; the historical ASEM gap ended when India joined in 2007.
- ANALYSIS: **BRICS/SCO's mixed membership dilutes coherence:** platforms including both India and its key strategic-mistrust partner (China, and in SCO's case also Pakistan) inherently limit how far collective positions can advance India-specific priorities without negotiation and compromise.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Charter entered into force on 20 May 2024, formalising the grouping's institutional/legal status; the 6th Summit (Bangkok, 4 April 2025) adopted BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030.
- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation, signed 3 April 2025, entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand.
- CURRENT: The BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration was issued at the 17th Summit, 6-7 July 2025; BRICS has 11 full members plus 10 partner countries.
- FACT: Sikri documents a historical APEC/ASEM gap; India joined ASEM in 2007, while it remains outside APEC as of 3 August 2026.
- FACT: IBSA and RIC are specifically named by Sikri as "potentially significant" trilateral groupings, distinct from larger multilateral bodies.
- FACT: BIMSTEC's institutional lineage traces from BIMST-EC (Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation) to its renamed, expanded form.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: All of India's regional/global/minilateral groupings carry equivalent institutional weight. -> They range from treaty-bound charter bodies (BIMSTEC) to non-treaty consultative coalitions (Quad); effectiveness and obligation levels differ substantially.
- WRONG: India's platform-diversification strategy has been uniformly successful. -> APEC remains a current membership gap; ASEM is only a historical example because India joined in 2007.
- WRONG: Overlapping memberships indicate incoherent or directionless foreign policy. -> The overlap is a deliberate strategic-autonomy strategy - addressing distinct interests through distinct platforms without exclusive commitment to any one.
- WRONG: SAARC has been replaced by BIMSTEC in a formal institutional sense. -> SAARC continues to exist; BIMSTEC has simply gained relative diplomatic salience and institutional momentum (2024 Charter) as SAARC's own momentum has been constrained.

9. CURRENT: Current-anchor note

- CURRENT: The BIMSTEC Charter (in force 20 May 2024), the 6th BIMSTEC Summit and Bangkok Vision 2030 (4 April 2025), and the BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration (6-7 July 2025) remain key institutional anchors. India's launch of its BRICS 2026 chairship logo, theme and website on 13 January 2026 is the latest chairship-process anchor; it is not a completed summit outcome. CURRENT: Two further markers - the partial entry into force of the BIMSTEC maritime transport agreement (16 May 2026) and the Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting (New Delhi, 26 May 2026) - show the two ends of the effectiveness spectrum operating in the same month: a treaty binding four states, and a non-treaty coalition launching initiatives without any ratification step at all.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: **2020 Quad PYQ:** reject the question's alliance/trade-bloc premise before evaluating functional expansion.
- FACT: **2021 SCO PYQ:** assess aims and objectives against India's continental security/connectivity interests and Pakistan-China constraints.
- FACT: **2022 I2U2 PYQ:** analyse transformation of India's global position

through issue-based minilateralism, not bloc alignment.

- ANALYSIS: No 2024-2025 question directly names a single grouping. An advanced analytical answer should:

1. Categorise groupings by layer (regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance, minilateral) rather than listing them undifferentiated.
2. Distinguish institutional-effectiveness levels (treaty-bound vs. non-treaty).
3. Cite the BIMSTEC Charter, Bangkok Vision 2030, the BRICS Rio de Janeiro Declaration and India's BRICS 2026 chairship launch at the correct evidentiary level, and distinguish full membership from partner/observer tiers.
4. Acknowledge membership gaps (APEC/ASEM) honestly rather than presenting uniform diplomatic success.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: India's five-layer grouping architecture - regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral - is a deliberate strategic-autonomy strategy: overlapping memberships address distinct, non-identical interests, and stagnation or exclusion in any single grouping does not compromise India's broader diplomatic position, though real coordination costs and institutional-effectiveness variance are genuine, ongoing limitations.

1. **Categorise the grouping by layer** before analysing its specific role.
2. **Distinguish institutional-effectiveness levels** (treaty-bound vs. non-treaty).
3. **Cite the dated BIMSTEC/BRICS anchors** as concrete evidence, at the correct evidentiary level (charter in force, summit vision document, declaration, chairship launch).
4. **Acknowledge membership gaps honestly** (APEC/ASEM example).
5. **Explain the strategic-autonomy payoff** of deliberate overlap.
6. **Acknowledge coordination-cost and coherence-dilution limitations.**
7. **Close by linking back to multi-alignment** (topic 01) as the organising principle.

12. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** "Overlapping memberships in regional, global and minilateral groupings reflect strategic autonomy, not incoherence." Critically examine.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Distinguish regionalism and minilateralism as organising principles for India's diplomatic engagement.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (10 marks):** Assess the significance of the BIMSTEC Charter's 2024 entry into force for South Asian regionalism.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion: basic/10_Regional-Global-and-Minilateral-Groupings.md.
- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 2 - the levels-of-engagement table and Section 4's strategic-autonomy framework.
- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 01 (advanced) for the full strategic-autonomy/hedging analysis; topic 04 for Quad's asymmetry; topic 05 for SCO's connectivity role; topic 08 for BRICS/Global-South distinction; topic 12 for G20/BRICS linkage to Bretton Woods reform debates.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 6

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2020	GS-II	19	Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc	Discuss · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-II	19	Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India	Critically examine · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	10	BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives	Do you think and how are they similar · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2022	GS-II	19	I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics	How will it transform · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	9	Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role	Point out the role · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2023	GS-II	19	Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India	What is your opinion with reasons · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- Quadrilateral Security Dialogue shifting from alliance to trade bloc
- Aims and objectives of the SCO and its importance for India
- BIMSTEC compared with SAARC and foreign policy objectives
- I2U2 grouping and India's position in global politics
- Conflict affecting the functioning of the SCO and India's role
- Expansion of NATO and a stronger US-Europe partnership for India

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings: RAPID ACTOR, INSTRUMENT AND DATED-ANCHOR MAP

- 1. What this groupings owner holds and how its boundaries are routed:** This topic owns India's participation across regional, trans-regional, continental, global-governance and minilateral groupings as a single classification problem: which layer a body belongs to, what legal form it takes, what participation tier a state actually holds in it, which dated instrument it has produced and what claim that instrument can support; its distinctive feature is that overlapping membership is a deliberate design choice rather than diplomatic incoherence, and six General Studies Paper II Mains demands from 2020, 2021, 2022 and 2023 are routed here alongside a long objective ledger running from 2018 to 2026, while the Quad's maritime-security profile belongs to topic 04, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation's connectivity role to topic 05, the Global South category to topic 08 and the linkage between the Group of Twenty and United Nations or Bretton Woods reform to topic 12.
- 2. The five-layer architecture that classifies every grouping:** The owners sort every body India joins into five layers: a regional layer defined by geographic contiguity, holding the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation and Mekong-Ganga Cooperation; a trans-regional or oceanic layer holding the Indian Ocean Rim Association and the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative; a continental Eurasian layer holding the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation; a global economic-governance layer holding the Group of Twenty and BRICS; and a minilateral, issue-based layer holding the Quad, the Russia-India-China trilateral and I2U2; the owners require the layer to be named before the body is analysed, because layer decides the membership logic, the mandate and the kind of outcome the body can realistically produce, and a listing of groupings without categorisation is precisely what a comparison question penalises.
- 3. The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation and the difference between stagnation and dissolution:** The owners record the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation as a charter-based South Asian regional organisation with eight members and an observer tier whose last Summit held was the eighteenth, at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014, and whose momentum has been constrained by India-Pakistan tensions; they state flatly that the organisation continues to exist and that dissolution must not be asserted without a specific verified source, and they add the analytical point that continued underperformance of the South Asian framework is an unrealised regional-integration opportunity rather than a costless substitution by another body.
- 4. The Bay of Bengal grouping's institutional lineage and the Charter that formalised it:** The owners record that the Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation was originally the Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand Economic Cooperation grouping and was since renamed, so the two names are one institutional lineage and not two organisations, and that its Charter was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force on 20 May 2024, converting a looser cooperative framework into a charter-based regional organisation of seven members; the examinable consequence is that a regionalism answer can date the institutional deepening precisely instead of asserting an undated claim that regional cooperation has strengthened.
- 5. The sixth Summit instrument set and Bangkok Vision 2030:** The owners record that the sixth Summit of the Bay of Bengal grouping met at Bangkok on 4 April 2025 and adopted the Summit Declaration, BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030, the Rules of Procedure for BIMSTEC Mechanisms and the Eminent Persons Group report, endorsed the Leaders' Joint Statement on the Myanmar-Thailand earthquake of 28 March 2025, and that Bangladesh took the chair; the discipline attached is that a vision document, a rules-of-procedure text and an expert-group report are three different evidentiary levels within one cycle, none of which is a treaty obligation, so an answer must cite the instrument by its own name rather than describing the summit as having agreed a binding regional commitment.
- 6. Partial entry into force as the sharpest effectiveness datum:** The owners record that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among only four of the seven members, namely Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand, after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026, and they treat this as the clearest available demonstration that an agreement in force and an agreement binding the whole region are different claims; the analytical sharpening is that variable-geometry ratification, rather than summit reluctance, is where regional integration actually slows, and

the owners separately note that the framework agreement for a BIMSTEC free trade area dates from 8 February 2004 with no concluded free trade agreement verified.

7. **The Association of Southeast Asian Nations and the India-ASEAN framework:** The owners record the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as a treaty and charter-based Southeast Asian regional organisation of eleven members including Timor-Leste, admitted at the forty-seventh ASEAN Summit on 26 October 2025, with a separate dialogue-partner tier that India has held in full since 1995, and they record that the twenty-second ASEAN-India Summit met at Kuala Lumpur on the same day and that the current framework is the ASEAN-India Plan of Action to implement the ASEAN-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership for 2026 to 2030 while the review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement remained ongoing rather than concluded; the owners also record that ASEAN maintains separate trade agreements with China, South Korea, Japan, India, Australia-New Zealand and Hong Kong, and that the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.
8. **The Indian Ocean Rim Association as the trans-regional oceanic layer:** The owners record the Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier the Indian Ocean Rim Association for Regional Cooperation, as an intergovernmental regional organisation of twenty-three member states with twelve dialogue partners and a Secretariat at Ebene in Mauritius, that India assumed its two-year chair in November 2025 for 2025 to 2027, and that its twenty-fourth Council of Ministers met virtually on 21 May 2025 and adopted the Colombo Communique; they add that Tharoor cites this body explicitly as one of the platforms India engages alongside larger organisations under its multi-alignment approach, which makes it a citable example of reach that does not depend on geographic contiguity.
9. **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation membership as voice without privileged access:** The owners record the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation as a charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation with ten full members including China, Russia, Pakistan, India, Iran and Belarus, two observers in Afghanistan and Mongolia and fifteen dialogue partners, that India became a full member in 2017, that its 2025 summit at Tianjin on 31 August to 1 September 2025 adopted the Tianjin Declaration and that Kyrgyzstan chairs for 2025 to 2026; the qualification the owners insist on is that membership supplies a seat in continental security and connectivity dialogue but not exclusive influence, because Pakistan's simultaneous membership and China's weight mean common membership never implies common threat perceptions, and the connectivity detail belongs to topic 05.
10. **BRICS full membership against the partner-country category:** The owners record BRICS as an intergovernmental political and economic grouping rather than a treaty alliance, originally Brazil, Russia, India and China, later expanded with South Africa and further members to eleven full members, with a separate partner-country category of ten countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024, that the seventeenth Summit at Rio de Janeiro on 6-7 July 2025 issued the Rio de Janeiro Declaration, and that India launched its 2026 chairship theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026 under the formulation Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability; the owners require partner countries to be kept out of the membership count and a chairship launch to be kept apart from a completed summit outcome, since no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.
11. **The New Development Bank's actual against prospective membership:** The owners record that the New Development Bank has ten actual members, namely the five founders together with Bangladesh in 2021, the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026, and that several other states appear on its lists as prospective rather than actual members; the examinable point is that a development bank attached to a grouping has its own membership ladder that does not track the grouping's own membership or partner tiers, so an answer that reads a bank's prospective list as a settled membership figure misstates both institutions at once.
12. **The Group of Twenty's composition and the African Union's permanent membership:** The owners record the Group of Twenty as the informal premier forum for international economic cooperation, composed of nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union with guest countries and invited international organisations attending on a separate footing, that the African Union became a permanent member on 9 September 2023, that the 2025 Summit met at Johannesburg on 22-23 November 2025 and adopted a Leaders' Declaration and that the United States holds the 2026 presidency; they add Tharoor's framing that India's role in this forum runs parallel to its United Nations role rather than replacing it, which is why the global-governance layer must be presented as an

addition to, and never a substitute for, formal multilateral institutions.

13. **The Quad as a non-treaty minilateral and its dated meeting record:** The owners record the Quad as a non-treaty consultative minilateral of India, Australia, Japan and the United States with a maritime-security and Indo-Pacific cooperation focus and acknowledged asymmetry among its members' treaty relationships, that the most recent Leaders' Summit was at Wilmington, Delaware on 21 September 2024 and the most recent Foreign Ministers' Meeting in New Delhi on 26 May 2026, which launched the Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative and a Quad Initiative on Indo-Pacific Energy Security and announced a Quad Critical Minerals Framework, and that the Quad Critical Minerals Initiative was launched on 1 July 2025; the owners state honestly that India was announced as intended host of a Leaders' Summit but that no India-hosted Leaders' Summit and no formal postponement is officially verified, so the gap is stated rather than filled by assumption.
14. **The treaty alliance comparator and why it is not a Quad analogue:** The North Atlantic Treaty Organization page checked live on 2026-09-03 records that twelve countries signed the North Atlantic Treaty, also known as the Washington Treaty, on 4 April 1949 in Washington, D.C., naming Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, the United Kingdom and the United States, and that all twelve parliaments ratified within the following five months, while the alliance's own Article 5 page records that the attacks of 11 September 2001 led it to take action under Article 5 for the first and so far only time in its history, that the North Atlantic Council agreed a conditional determination on 12 September 2001 and confirmed it on 2 October 2001, that a package of eight support measures was agreed on 4 October 2001 and that Operation Eagle Assist ran from 9 October 2001 to mid-May 2002 with seven airborne early-warning aircraft, 830 crew members from 13 member countries and over 360 sorties; the owners add that Finland joined in 2023 and Sweden became the thirty-second member in March 2024, that the North Atlantic Council decides by consensus, and that India is neither a member nor a treaty ally, so the alliance affects India only indirectly through Russia-West confrontation, defence and technology alignment, sanctions coordination and the allocation of Western attention, and must never be conflated with a non-treaty functional minilateral that carries no collective-defence commitment.
15. **The two trilateral platforms and their asymmetric activity:** The owners record that Sikri names the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as potentially significant smaller platforms that let India engage major powers or Southern peers without the constraints of a larger and more heterogeneous body, that an India-Brazil-South Africa Leaders' Meeting was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 proposing a digital innovation alliance and a climate-resilient agriculture fund as proposals rather than established institutions, and that the Russia-India-China trilateral has no officially verified meeting since the eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting convened virtually on 26 November 2021; the owners require this asymmetry to be stated candidly whenever the two are listed together, because presenting them as equally active misdescribes the ledger.
16. **Mekong-Ganga Cooperation and the subregional connectivity layer:** The owners record Mekong-Ganga Cooperation as a six-member ministerial cooperation mechanism linking India with Cambodia, Lao People's Democratic Republic, Myanmar, Thailand and Viet Nam under the broader Act East policy, and that the most recent ministerial meeting located officially is the tenth, at Bangkok on 1 August 2019; they route the physical connectivity projects that operationalise Act East, including the Kaladan multi-modal project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway, to the neighbourhood owner, so this topic carries the mechanism and its dated meeting record while the corridor engineering and its delivery record belong elsewhere.
17. **Membership and regime distinctions the objective paper tests directly:** The owners assemble the export-control and financial-institution distinctions that the objective ledger repeatedly targets: India joined the Missile Technology Control Regime as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, and that regime is a voluntary export-control arrangement giving rule access rather than a treaty guaranteeing technology transfer; India is not a member of the Nuclear Suppliers Group and its application is distinct from the 2008 India-specific waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce, because a waiver is not membership and admission requires consensus; India is a founding member and the second-largest shareholder of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank after China, which supplies finance access and a governance stake without unilateral control; and India's International Atomic Energy Agency safeguards Additional Protocol entered into force on 25 July 2014, applying to its safeguards arrangement without making it a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty.
18. **The membership-gap correction that keeps the record honest:** The owners record Sikri's observation that India had failed to obtain membership of either the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum or the Asia-Europe Meeting as a book-period statement rather than a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe

Meeting in 2007 while it remained outside the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation forum as of 3 August 2026; they treat the correction as a corrective to triumphalist narratives, since platform diversification has not been uniformly successful, and they require the surviving example to be dated whenever it is used so that a period-specific source claim is never presented as a present-day fact.

19. **Overlap as strategic-autonomy design and the coordination cost it carries:** The owners argue that overlapping memberships are a deliberate strategic-autonomy asset rather than institutional redundancy, because each layer addresses a distinct interest and stagnation or exclusion in any one body does not incapacitate the wider architecture, and they anchor the argument in Tharoor's own pairing list of both the United Nations and the Group of Twenty, both the Non-Aligned Movement and the Community of Democracies, both the Group of Seventy-Seven and the Indian Ocean Rim body, and both the South Asian association and ASEAN-linked engagement; the owners then attach three genuine costs in the same place, namely the diplomatic bandwidth and scheduling trade-offs of engaging five layers at once, the analytical imprecision of treating a treaty-bound charter body and a non-treaty coalition as equally binding, and the coherence dilution that follows from platforms containing both India and its principal strategic-mistrust partners.
20. **Honest question ownership for this groupings owner:** The audited ledgers route six General Studies Paper II Mains demands to this owner, each on a Core route recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership: 2020 question 19 on the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue allegedly transforming itself from a military alliance into a trade bloc, a Discuss demand of 15 marks and 250 words for which the 2020 paper is not among the locally held official papers, so the wording is carried from the ledger and the owner rather than confirmed here; 2021 question 19 asking to critically examine the aims and objectives of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the importance it holds for India, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question itself; 2022 question 10 asking whether the Bay of Bengal grouping is a parallel organisation like the South Asian association, what the similarities and dissimilarities are and how Indian foreign-policy objectives are realized by forming it, a 10-mark demand whose 150-word limit is printed in the question; 2022 question 19 on how the I2U2 grouping will transform India's position in global politics, a 15-mark demand whose 250-word limit is printed in the question; 2023 question 9 stating that a virus of conflict is affecting the functioning of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and asking the answer to point out India's role in mitigating the problems, a 10-mark demand whose printed tail carries only the mark value so that its 150-word limit comes from the paper's instruction block; and 2023 question 19 on whether the expansion and strengthening of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization and a stronger United States-Europe strategic partnership works well for India, a 15-mark demand on the same instruction-block provenance; the objective ledgers additionally route seventeen demands from 2018 to 2023, four from 2024 to 2025 and three from 2026 to this owner, and because the 2018-2023 official keys are not held locally, the 2024-2025 Set-A keys are held and the 2026 Set-A key is provisional, no option, answer letter or inferred key is recorded for any of them.

Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings: CLOSE-OPTION AND STATUS-UPGRADE TRAPS

- Do not assert that the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation has been dissolved, because the owners record it as a continuing charter-based organisation whose summit momentum has been constrained since the eighteenth Summit at Kathmandu on 26-27 November 2014.
- Do not treat the Bay of Bengal grouping and its earlier Bangladesh-India-Myanmar-Sri Lanka-Thailand name as two organisations, because the renamed body is one institutional lineage.
- Do not describe the Bay of Bengal grouping as replacing the South Asian association in a formal institutional sense, because the second body continues to exist and the first has only gained relative salience and institutional momentum.
- Do not date the Charter of the Bay of Bengal grouping by its adoption alone, because it was adopted at Colombo on 30 March 2022 and entered into force only on 20 May 2024.
- Do not present BIMSTEC Bangkok Vision 2030 as a binding regional commitment, because the sixth Summit of 4 April 2025 adopted a Summit Declaration, a vision document, Rules of Procedure and an Eminent Persons Group report, which are four different evidentiary levels and none of them a treaty obligation.
- Do not state that the BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation binds all seven members, because it was signed on 3 April 2025 and entered into force on 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar and Thailand after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026.

- Do not claim a concluded free trade agreement for the Bay of Bengal grouping, because the owners record only a framework agreement dating from 8 February 2004.
- Do not treat India's full dialogue-partner status with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations, held since 1995, as membership of it, and do not read the ongoing review of the ASEAN-India Trade in Goods Agreement as a concluded review.
- Do not describe India as a member of the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, because the owners record that it links ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea and New Zealand while India is not a member.
- Do not merge the twenty-three member states of the Indian Ocean Rim Association with its twelve dialogue partners, and do not convert India's 2025 to 2027 chair term into an institutional power over the Association.
- Do not infer common threat perceptions from common membership of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, because Pakistan and China are simultaneously full members and India's 2017 accession supplies voice rather than privileged access.
- Do not count the ten BRICS partner countries created through the Kazan process on 24 October 2024 among its eleven full members, because the partner category confers participation without the rights and obligations of membership.
- Do not treat India's BRICS 2026 chairship, launched with a theme, logo and website on 13 January 2026, as evidence that a 2026 Leaders' Summit was held, because no such summit outcome was officially verified as of 3 August 2026.
- Do not read the New Development Bank's prospective list as membership, because the owners record ten actual members, namely the five founders with Bangladesh and the United Arab Emirates in 2021, Egypt in 2023, Algeria in 2025 and Uzbekistan in 2026.
- Do not treat guest countries or invited international organisations at the Group of Twenty as members, because its composition is nineteen states plus the European Union and the African Union, which became a permanent member on 9 September 2023.
- Do not call the Quad a treaty alliance comparable to the North Atlantic Treaty Organization, because the Quad is a non-treaty consultative minilateral with no collective-defence commitment, while the alliance was founded by twelve signatories of the North Atlantic Treaty on 4 April 1949 and has invoked Article 5 once in its history, after the attacks of 11 September 2001.
- Do not assume either an India-hosted Quad Leaders' Summit or a formal postponement, because the owners record only that India was announced as intended host and that neither outcome is officially verified.
- Do not present the India-Brazil-South Africa Initiative and the Russia-India-China trilateral as equally active, because a Leaders' Meeting of the first was held at Johannesburg on 23 November 2025 while the second has no officially verified meeting since the virtual eighteenth Foreign Ministers' Meeting of 26 November 2021.
- Do not convert the digital innovation alliance and climate-resilient agriculture fund discussed at Johannesburg into established institutions, because the owners record them as proposals.
- Do not describe membership of the Missile Technology Control Regime, which India joined as its thirty-fifth member on 27 June 2016, as a guarantee of technology transfer, because it is a voluntary export-control arrangement.
- Do not equate the 2008 India-specific civil nuclear waiver with membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group, because India is not a member and admission requires consensus.
- Do not read India's Additional Protocol, in force since 25 July 2014, as making India a non-nuclear-weapon State under the Non-Proliferation Treaty, because it applies to India's safeguards arrangement alone.
- Do not repeat Sikri's Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation and Asia-Europe Meeting gap as a current two-forum gap, because India joined the Asia-Europe Meeting in 2007 and only the Asia-Pacific forum remained a gap as of 3 August 2026.
- Do not present overlapping membership as evidence of directionless foreign policy, and equally do not present it as costless, because the owners record diplomatic bandwidth trade-offs, institutional-effectiveness variance and coherence dilution as genuine limitations.

- Do not invent a grouping membership or accession, a participation tier, a charter, treaty or agreement provision, a signature, ratification or entry-into-force date, a summit, declaration or vision outcome, a chairship or presidency claim, a trade, investment or financing figure, a previous-year question, an answer key or a current claim for this topic.

Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings: ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

NAME INDIA'S PRECISE INTEREST -> IDENTIFY THE EXTERNAL ACTOR AND ITS OWN INCENTIVE
-> CHOOSE THE LEVEL: BILATERAL, REGIONAL, MINILATERAL, MULTILATERAL OR DIASPORA
-> CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT AND STATE ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL
-> SEPARATE ANNOUNCED FROM SIGNED, SIGNED FROM IN FORCE, IN FORCE FROM DELIVERED
-> NAME THE BINDING CONSTRAINT: ASYMMETRY, RIVAL POWER, PARTNER POLITICS OR CAPACITY
-> CLOSE WITH A CALIBRATED WAY FORWARD AND AN EXPLICIT STRATEGIC-AUTONOMY LINK

Regional, Global and Minilateral Groupings: LIVE-SOURCE AND DATED-CLAIM BOUNDARY

Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for this topic: the Ministry of External Affairs pages first, then the secretariats of the groupings themselves, then the treaty-alliance comparator. Every outcome is recorded exactly as observed. The Ministry of External Affairs press-release, bilateral-document and country-brief pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page, the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, the BIMSTEC Secretariat returned HTTP 404 on its about page and unreadable markup on its home page, the ASEAN membership page returned a redirect without a Location header, the Indian Ocean Rim Association and Shanghai Cooperation Organisation pages returned only title lines, the Group of Twenty page returned HTTP 403 and the BRICS chairship site failed with a host-resolution error, so no grouping membership, participation tier, summit outcome or chairship claim was obtained from any of them. The two North Atlantic Treaty Organization pages did return substantive official text, and they are used here only for the founding and Article 5 facts those pages actually state. The package therefore uses the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners together with that single verified alliance source, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no grouping membership or accession, no observer, partner, dialogue-partner or guest status, no charter, treaty or agreement provision, no signature, ratification or entry-into-force date, no summit, declaration or vision document outcome, no chairship or presidency claim, no trade, investment or financing figure, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Central question and the five-layer answer

CENTRAL QUESTION -> why does India join so many overlapping groupings?
ANSWER -> each layer buys a different, non-identical interest
LAYER 1 REGIONAL -> SAARC | BIMSTEC | Mekong-Ganga Cooperation
LAYER 2 TRANS-REGIONAL -> IORA | IBSA
LAYER 3 CONTINENTAL -> Shanghai Cooperation Organisation
LAYER 4 GLOBAL GOVERNANCE -> Group of Twenty | BRICS
LAYER 5 MINILATERAL -> Quad | Russia-India-China | I2U2
RULE -> name the layer before analysing the body
BOUNDARY -> Quad maritime security to topic 04; SCO connectivity to topic 05;
Global South to topic 08; UN and Bretton Woods reform linkage to topic 12
MUST REMEMBER: Regional, global and minilateral groupings vary by treaty basis,...
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ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: South Asian layer read as a dated record

26-27 NOVEMBER 2014 -> 18th SAARC Summit at Kathmandu, the last Summit held
STATUS -> charter-based body, 8 members plus observers, still in existence
8 FEBRUARY 2004 -> BIMSTEC free trade area framework agreement; no FTA concluded
30 MARCH 2022 -> BIMSTEC Charter adopted at Colombo
20 MAY 2024 -> BIMSTEC Charter enters into force; 7 members
4 APRIL 2025 -> 6th BIMSTEC Summit, Bangkok; Bangladesh takes the chair
adopts Summit Declaration, Bangkok Vision 2030, Rules of Procedure,
Eminent Persons Group report; endorses the 28 March 2025 earthquake statement
RULE -> renamed BIMST-EC and BIMSTEC are one lineage, not two organisations

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: Where regional integration actually slows

PROBLEM -> summit outputs are read as regional obligations
RESPONSE: a declaration, a vision document, rules of procedure and an expert
report are four evidentiary levels and none is a treaty obligation
PROBLEM -> an agreement in force is read as binding the whole region
RESPONSE: BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation signed
3 April 2025; in force 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Thailand
after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026
DIAGNOSIS -> variable-geometry ratification, not summit reluctance
RULE -> in force for four of seven is the answer-grabbing formulation

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Participation tiers and what each one confers

SAARC	-> 8 members	observers
BIMSTEC	-> 7 members	no separate tier recorded
ASEAN	-> 11 members	dialogue partners; India full since 1995
Timor-Leste admitted at the 47th ASEAN Summit, 26 October 2025		
IORA	-> 23 member states	12 dialogue partners
SCO	-> 10 members	2 observers, 15 dialogue partners
BRICS	-> 11 full members	10 partner countries, from 24 Oct 2024
G20	-> 19 states + EU + AU	guests and invited organisations
QUAD	-> 4 participants	non-treaty consultative minilateral
RULE -> tiers expand reach without expanding decision rights		

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Southeast Asian architecture and the trade-agreement map

22nd ASEAN-INDIA SUMMIT -> Kuala Lumpur, 26 October 2025
FRAMEWORK -> ASEAN-India Plan of Action for the Comprehensive Strategic
Partnership, 2026-2030
AITIGA REVIEW -> ongoing, expressly not concluded
ASEAN FTA PARTNERS -> China | South Korea | Japan | India |
Australia-New Zealand | Hong Kong
RCEP -> ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea, New Zealand
INDIA IN RCEP -> not a member
TRAP -> an ASEAN dialogue or trade partner is not thereby an ASEAN member

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: Oceanic and continental layers with their dated outcomes

IORA -> Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier IOR-ARC
Secretariat at Ebene, Mauritius; India chairs 2025-27, assumed November 2025
24th Council of Ministers met virtually 21 May 2025; Colombo Communiqué cited by Tharoor as a platform engaged alongside larger bodies
SCO -> charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation
India a full member since 2017; China, Russia, Pakistan, Iran, Belarus inside
Tianjin summit 31 August-1 September 2025; Tianjin Declaration
Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26
LIMIT -> a seat supplies voice, never privileged access or shared threat views

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Global-governance layer counted correctly

BRICS -> 11 full members; not a treaty alliance
partner-country category of 10 created through the Kazan process, 24 Oct 2024
17th Summit, Rio de Janeiro, 6-7 July 2025 -> Rio de Janeiro Declaration
India chairship 2026 launched 13 January 2026 with theme, logo and website
no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome officially verified as of 3 August 2026
NEW DEVELOPMENT BANK -> 10 actual members
five founders + Bangladesh 2021, UAE 2021, Egypt 2023, Algeria 2025, Uzbekistan 2026; other states listed as prospective, not actual
G20 -> African Union a permanent member from 9 September 2023
Johannesburg Summit 22-23 November 2025; United States holds 2026 presidency

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Minilateral against treaty alliance

QUAD -> India, Australia, Japan, United States; non-treaty consultative
Leaders' Summit: Wilmington, Delaware, 21 September 2024
Foreign Ministers: New Delhi, 26 May 2026 -> Indo-Pacific Maritime Security Cooperation initiative; Indo-Pacific Energy Security initiative;
Critical Minerals Framework announced; Critical Minerals Initiative 1 July 2025
India announced as intended host; no held summit and no postponement verified
NATO -> North Atlantic Treaty signed 4 April 1949, Washington, D.C., 12 states
Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, United Kingdom, United States; ratified within five months
Article 5 invoked once ever, after 11 September 2001; confirmed 2 October 2001
Finland joined 2023; Sweden the 32nd member, March 2024; Council by consensus
DECISIVE LINE -> collective defence is a treaty obligation; the Quad has none

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: How the alliance reaches India without India being in it

RUSSIA CHANNEL -> post-2022 consolidation deepens Russia-West confrontation
-> pressure on defence spares, energy, payments and diplomatic balancing
EUROPE CHANNEL -> Finland and Sweden expand northern geography
-> stronger United States-Europe coordination, but attention and defence industrial capacity can shift toward Europe
TECHNOLOGY CHANNEL -> tighter export-control and sanctions coordination
-> exposure for Indian firms and technology partnerships
INDIAN RESPONSE -> diversify defence supply; deepen India-EU and bilateral European ties; keep issue-based Russia engagement; refuse alliance logic
RULE -> analyse transmission, not membership, when India is outside the body

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: Trilateral platforms and the subregional mechanism

IBSA -> India, Brazil, South Africa; Sikri: potentially significant
Leaders' Meeting, Johannesburg, 23 November 2025
digital innovation alliance and climate-resilient agriculture fund proposed
STATUS -> proposals, expressly not established institutions
RIC -> Russia, India, China; also named by Sikri
no officially verified meeting since the virtual 18th Foreign Ministers'
Meeting of 26 November 2021
MEKONG-GANGA -> 6 members: Cambodia, India, Lao PDR, Myanmar, Thailand, Viet Nam
most recent ministerial located officially: the 10th, Bangkok, 1 August 2019
corridor engineering routes to the neighbourhood owner
DISCIPLINE -> state the asymmetry whenever the platforms are listed together
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Member, observer, dialogue partner, guest, chair and invited...
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Member, observer, dialogue partner, guest, chair and invited...
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Member, observer, dialogue partner, guest, chair and invited...

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Regime vocabulary that decides objective questions

MTCR -> India the 35th member, 27 June 2016
voluntary export-control arrangement; rule access, not guaranteed transfer
NSG -> India not a member; application distinct from the 2008 India-specific
waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce; admission needs consensus
AIIB -> India a founding member and the second-largest shareholder after China
finance access and a governance stake, never unilateral control
SCO -> India a full member since 2017; access without shared threat perception
IAEA ADDITIONAL PROTOCOL -> in force 25 July 2014; applies to safeguards only
it does not make India a non-nuclear-weapon State under the NPT
GAP -> ASEM joined 2007; APEC still a non-membership example, 3 August 2026
EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Verify current membership and...
EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Verify current membership and...
EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Verify current membership and...

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Answer spine for a groupings or minilateralism demand

OPEN -> name the layer, the legal form and the exact participation tier
EVIDENCE -> one dated instrument with its precise evidentiary level attached
COMPARE -> treaty-bound charter body against non-treaty coalition, both named
TEST -> separate announced, signed, in force and in force for how many members
CONCEDE -> bandwidth cost, effectiveness variance, coherence dilution
OWNERSHIP -> the 2020 Quad, 2021 and 2023 SCO, 2022 BIMSTEC-SAARC, 2022 I2U2
and 2023 alliance-expansion demands are the routed Mains questions
CLOSE -> form must match the problem; multiplying memberships without delivery
or status precision produces only diplomatic symbolism